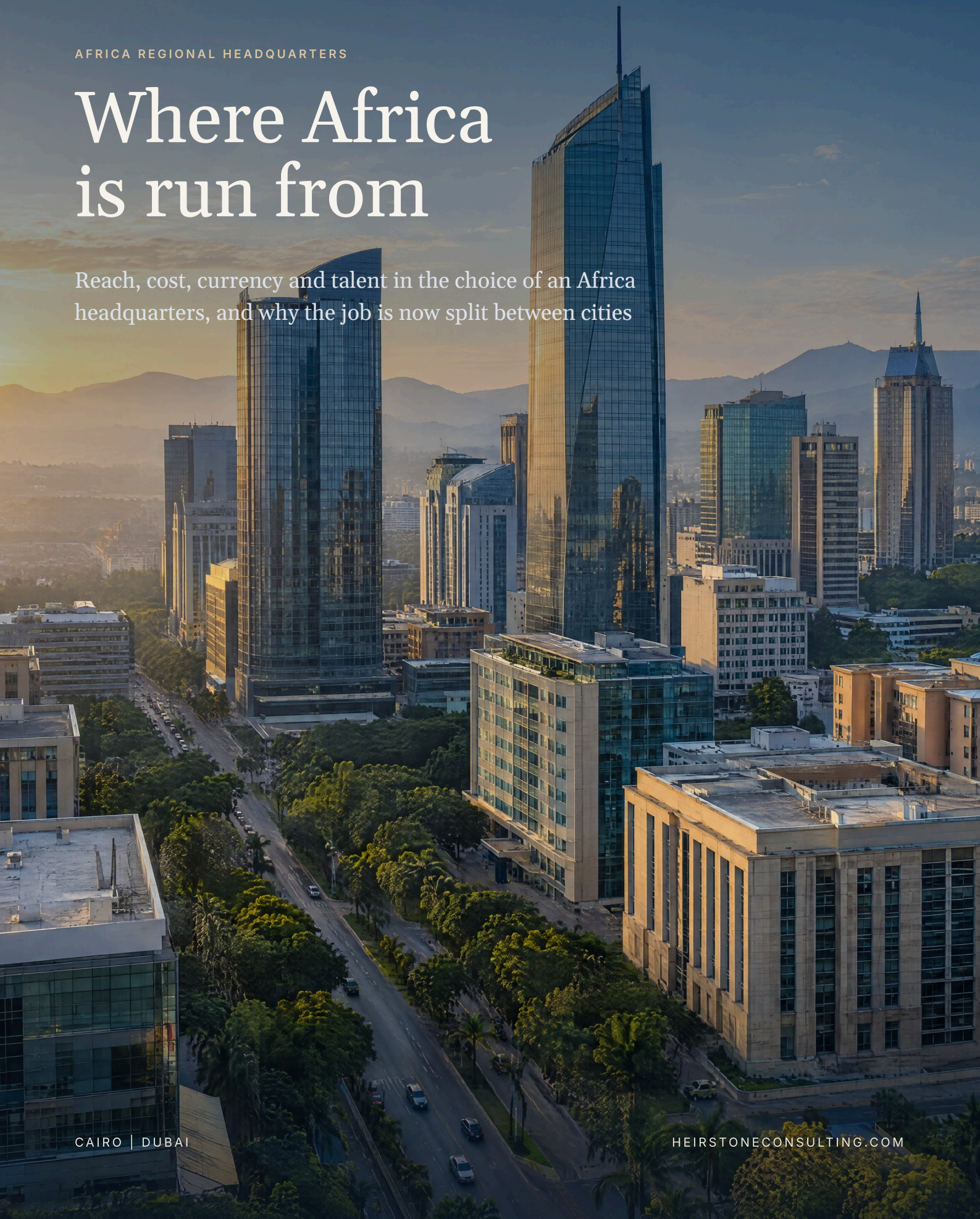
HEIRSTONE CONSULTING

AFRICA REGIONAL HEADQUARTERS

Where Africa is run from

Reach, cost, currency and talent in the choice of an Africa headquarters, and why the job is now split between cities



SIX NUMBERS FROM THIS REPORT

38

African capitals reached non-stop from Addis Ababa in 2026, against 26 from Casablanca, 23 from Johannesburg and 22 from Nairobi

5 of 28

city pairs across the francophone and anglophone groups of candidate cities that have a non-stop flight

8 to 33%

share of office rent in the location cost of a 50-person headquarters in nine cities; schooling takes 28 to 66%

US$1.69m

yearly location cost of that headquarters in Dakar, against US$0.56m in Cape Town (Heirstone model, upper-bound inputs for Dakar)

31.1m

passengers through Cairo International in 2025, the most of any airport in Africa

0 of 17

cities in the Heirstone Africa HQ Index that pass the gates for all five headquarters roles

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

Heirstone Consulting advises corporates, investors, developers and governments across the Middle East and Africa on markets, location and real estate strategy. This report asks where companies and institutions put the headquarters that runs their African business, and what decides it. It draws only on public sources current in 2026: company and institution releases, airline schedules, central bank and statistics data, regulators, tax summaries, school fee schedules and published research.

Three tools are our own: the Heirstone Africa HQ Register of named, sourced cases; a cost model for a 50-person regional headquarters; and the Heirstone Africa HQ Index of 16 African cities with Dubai as a benchmark. Every derived figure is labelled Heirstone analysis and shown with its inputs. Local-currency amounts are converted at 2026 rates unless stated.

WHAT WE FOUND

No African city passes every headquarters test, and many companies now split the job between cities

An Africa headquarters must be reachable from the continent's capitals, affordable for an expatriate leadership team, safe for the cash it holds and staffed from a deep graduate pool. We tested 16 African cities and Dubai against those four requirements. The leaders differ on each one.

1 **Many groups still manage Africa from abroad.**

Dubai Chambers counted 30,409 African member companies in 2025, many of them traders. In Infomineo's 2017 count of Global 500 firms, Dubai hosted 155 regional headquarters for the Middle East or the whole region and Johannesburg 29. GE and Nokia (2005) and Medtronic (2014) set up Middle East and Africa headquarters in Dubai; Airtel Africa, Helios Towers and Vivo Energy are based in London.

2 **At most hubs, one airline sets the reach.**

Addis Ababa reaches 38 of the 53 other African capitals non-stop, and Ethiopian Airlines flies 97% of its routes. Istanbul reaches 29, more than any African airport except Addis; Dubai reaches 17. Cairo, Africa's busiest airport with 31.1m passengers in 2025, reaches 18 capitals and 11 of the other 15 candidate cities.

3 **The air map splits by language.**

All six pairs among the four francophone and Maghreb cities we tested have a non-stop flight, and 16 of 21 among the seven anglophone ones. Across the language line only 5 of 28 do. Casablanca reaches all 12 ECOWAS capitals; Lagos, Accra, Abidjan and Dakar each reach 6 of the other 11.

4 **Schools and housing cost more than offices.**

For a 50-person headquarters with eight expatriate families, office rent is 8 to 33% of the location cost in nine cities and schooling 28 to 66%. On our assumptions the bill is about US$1.69m a year in Dakar and US$0.56m in Cape Town. Lagos has Knight Frank's dearest prime offices, US$55 per sq m a month, yet ranked 225th of 226 in Mercer's 2024 expatriate cost survey.

5 **Hard-anchor currencies held their value.**

The CFA franc gained 3.7% since end-2015 and the Moroccan dirham 1.0%. Several large markets adjusted through dated devaluations and floats; Egypt, the second-largest host economy, floated in March 2024, the year its net FDI inflows reached US$46.58bn. Only Morocco and Mauritius are rated investment grade.

6 **Five roles, and no city passes every gate.**

Casablanca tops our index under all four weightings we tested, yet it reaches 6 of 22 anglophone capitals. Only Addis Ababa and Nairobi pass our gateway test; only Johannesburg, Cape Town and Casablanca pass our command test. A Casablanca and Johannesburg pair reaches 45 of 54 African countries non-stop.

WHAT IT MEANS

Boards should decide which of the five headquarters roles they need before choosing a city. A pan-African mandate usually needs a hub on each side of the language line.

Governments and agencies should bid for a role they can win and fix the gate they fail, whether visas, school places or access to foreign exchange.

Investors and developers should price the whole package a headquarters tenant needs: Grade A space, international school places and executive housing within one commute.

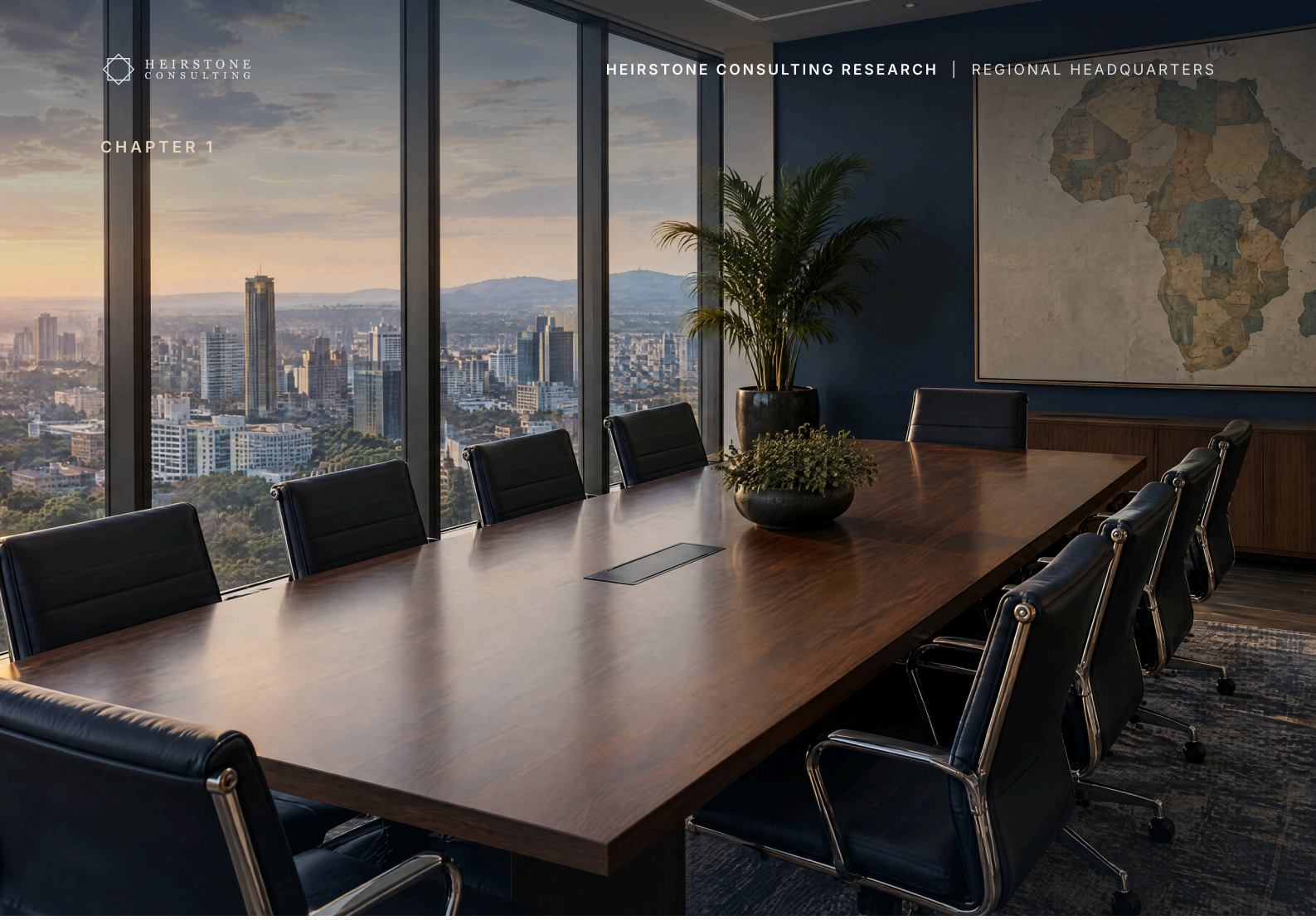
17

cities in the Heirstone Africa HQ Index: 16 in Africa, with Dubai scored as a benchmark

82

named, sourced cases in the Heirstone Africa HQ Register, 2026

CHAPTER 1



01

The headquarters has come apart

A regional headquarters once meant one building and one leadership team. For Africa it now usually means several entities in several cities, some of them outside the continent.

In April 2005 GE announced a 65,000 sq ft Middle East and Africa headquarters at Dubai Internet City, to be operational by May 2006 with more than 250 staff. In October 2005 Nokia opened its own Middle East and Africa headquarters in the same free zone, for the executives covering Africa, the Middle East, Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Both companies also placed parts of the Africa job in African cities. In 2015 BizNews, a South African business site, reported that GE had chosen Nairobi over Sandton for its Africa headquarters. In April 2026 Nokia said Egypt would house a new technical support hub for the Middle East and Africa.

The same pattern recurs in the public record we assembled. The regional chief executive and the P&L often sit in Dubai, London or another European capital. The entities with an explicit Africa mandate, such as a treasury company, a services company, a fund vehicle or a technical hub, sit in African cities chosen for a tax regime, a graduate pool or an airport.

This chapter sets out where those pieces sit. Chapters 2 to 4 test the cities on reach, cost and currency; chapter 5 combines the tests.

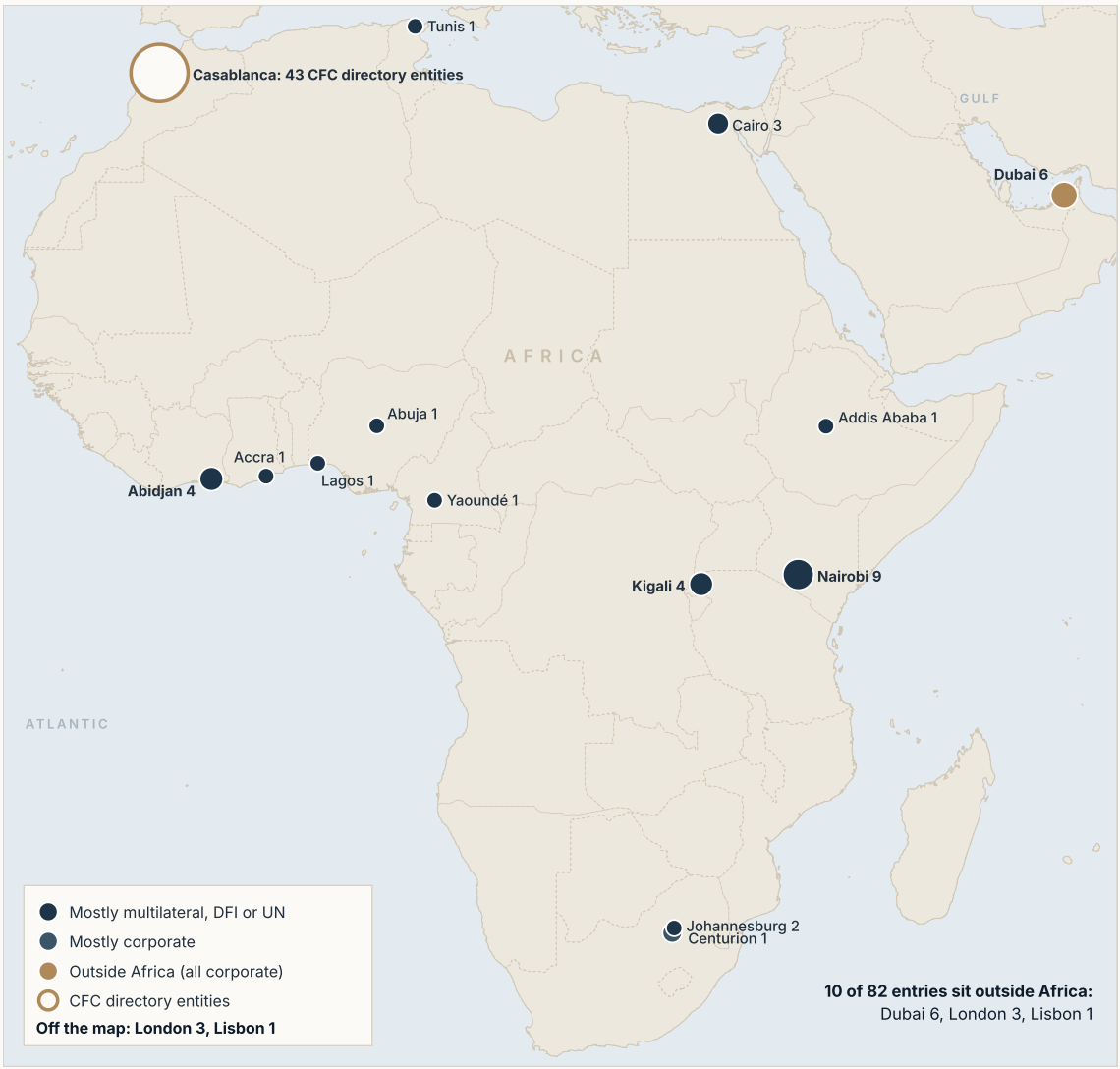
THE HEIRSTONE AFRICA HQ REGISTER

Eighty-two named cases, and why they should not be read as market shares

EXHIBIT 1

Outside Casablanca's directory, Nairobi holds the most named cases, and a quarter of those cases sit outside Africa

Organisations with a sourced Africa, Sub-Saharan, North Africa or Middle East and Africa headquarters, hub or regional entity, by city; circle area scales with entries



Source: Heirstone Africa HQ Register (pilot, 2026): company releases, official websites, company registries and press for 39 entries; Casablanca Finance City public member directory (accessed 2026) for 43 entities whose names carry a regional mandate or belong to a named group. Directory entities are not necessarily group headquarters. City-centre positions from GeoNames.

The register lists every organisation whose Africa, Sub-Saharan, North Africa or Middle East and Africa headquarters, hub or regional entity we could trace to a public source: 32 rows from company, official, registry or press pages, 7 from headlines only, whose article text we could not check, and 43 from the Casablanca Finance City (CFC) member directory. Casablanca is over-represented because the CFC publishes its members; Dubai and Johannesburg are probably under-represented, because few of the regional offices there could be confirmed from a primary source.

Each count is therefore a floor. Even so, two patterns hold. Nairobi has the most entries outside the CFC directory, 9, and 5 of them are multilateral, development finance or UN bodies, so its lead is institutional. And all ten entries outside Africa are corporate.

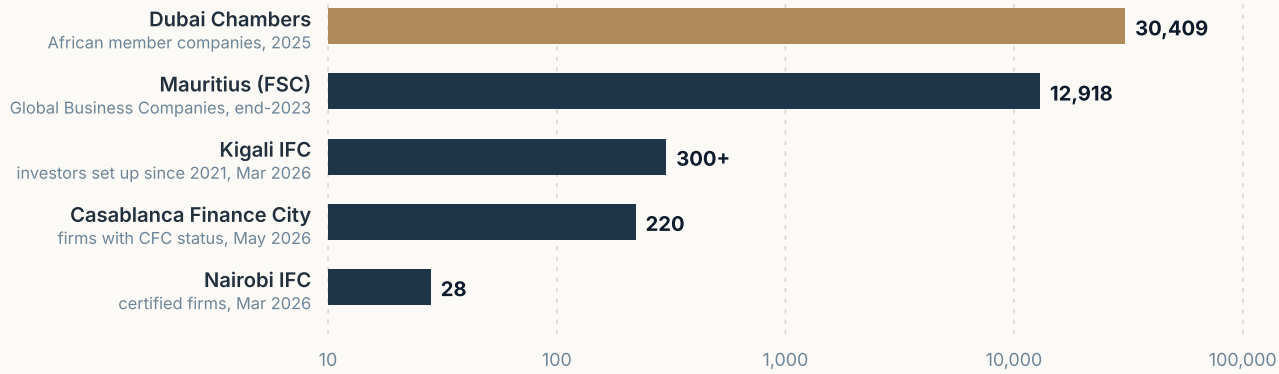
SCALE

African companies in Dubai's chamber outnumber the firms in any African financial centre

EXHIBIT 2

Dubai's chamber lists about 138 African companies for every firm with Casablanca Finance City status

Firms, licences or members by centre, latest published count; log scale. Each centre counts something different, so the bars show orders of magnitude only



Source: Dubai Chambers (2025) via African Business (June 2026); FSC Mauritius, Annual Statistical Bulletin 2024; KIFC official interviewed by TechCabal (19 March 2026); Wafir.ma citing the CFC Authority (2026, grade C); IT Edge News (2026, grade C). Ratio is **Heirstone analysis** (30,409 / 220).

The five counts measure different things. Dubai Chambers counts African companies that have joined its chamber, 26,910 at end-2024 and 30,409 in 2025; many are trading firms. Mauritius counts licences: 12,918 Global Business Companies and 6,296 Authorised Companies at end-2023, with assets of about US$753bn. The CFC counts firms with its status, which requires a resident manager in Morocco. Kigali's 300-plus is an official's count of investors set up, given in an interview.

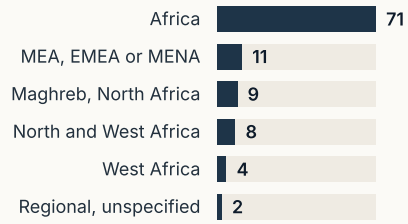
Read as orders of magnitude, the gap is still wide. Dubai Chambers runs seven representative offices in Africa, and Dubai-Africa non-oil trade reached US$146bn in 2025, according to African Business citing the chamber. The CFC opened its own representative office in Dubai during Covid-19 and credited it with 15 to 20% of installation decisions: African centres are recruiting from the Gulf's pool of regional offices.

Growth at the African centres has been slow. The CFC had 196 member companies at end-2021, 202 in January 2024 and about 220 in May 2026 according to Wafir.ma, roughly five a year, after a goal of 500 by 2025 was dropped in 2021, as Medias24 reported. The Nairobi centre attracted three firms in its first three years, had certified 28 by March 2026 according to IT Edge News, and added 15 on 1 July 2026.

EXHIBIT 3

Two in five CFC directory entities carry a regional mandate in their name

105 of about 270 entities, by scope keyword, 2026



Source: Heirstone analysis of the CFC public member directory, 2026. A keyword does not prove headquarters status.

51%

of CFC members were active in Côte d'Ivoire at end-2021; 45% in Senegal, 34% in Tunisia and 29% in Cameroon (CFC Authority)

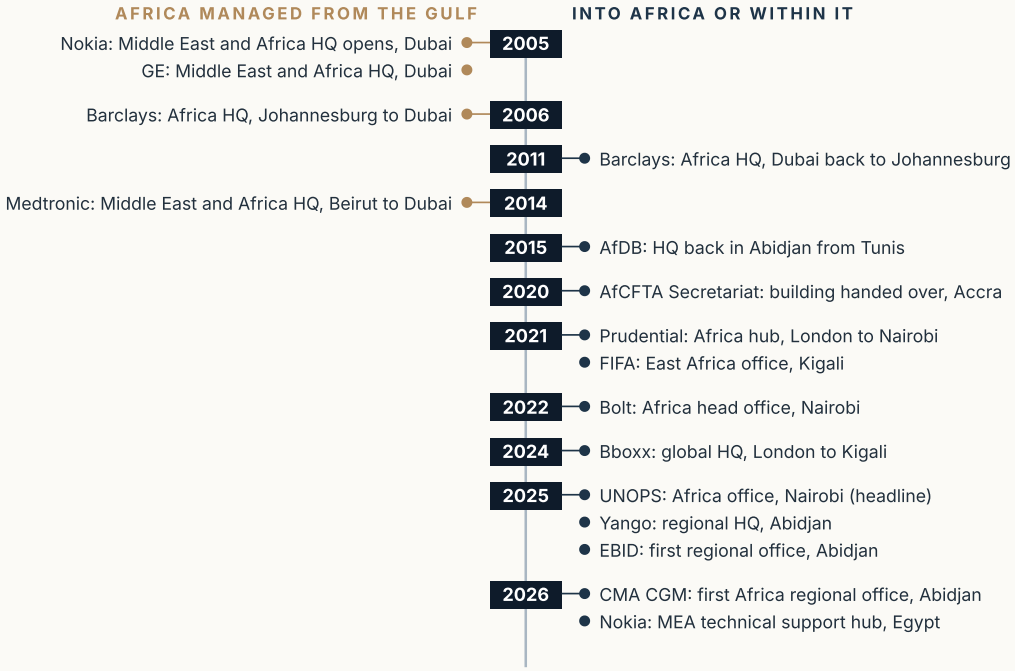
MOVES

The register's early moves went to Dubai; its dated moves since 2020 went into or within Africa

EXHIBIT 4

Two decades of Africa headquarters moves in the register

Dated openings and relocations of Africa or Middle East and Africa headquarters, hubs and seats, 2005 to 2026



Source: Heirstone Africa HQ Register: GE (30 April 2005); Tech Africa (12 October 2005); Retail Banker International (9 May 2011); Healio (4 February 2014); AfDB, history (2026); AfCFTA Secretariat (2026); Kenya News Agency (2025, headline); Business Daily Africa (24 October 2021); KT Press (February 2021); The Condia (July 2022); Bboxx via NextBillion (7 February 2024); Financial Afrik (28 July 2025); African Business (December 2025, headline); Logistics Business Africa (14 February 2026); Enterprise (27 April 2026). Dubai-bound moves after 2014 could not be dated and are therefore absent.

Barclays shows how reversible the decision is: it moved its Africa headquarters from Johannesburg to Dubai in 2006 and back in 2011, to consolidate with Absa. Medtronic moved its Middle East and Africa headquarters from Beirut to Dubai in 2014, citing infrastructure, accessibility and Dubai's position as a gateway.

The recent moves into Africa are mostly operating heads and institutions. Prudential moved its Africa hub from London to Nairobi in 2021, citing talent and government facilitation. Bboxx moved its global headquarters from London to Kigali in 2024 and pledged US$100m of investment. CMA CGM opened its first Africa regional office in Abidjan in 2026; Financial Afrik reports that continental management moved there from Marseille.

We found no dated public announcement of an Africa headquarters moving to Dubai after 2014. That absence is a gap in the evidence, and we do not read it as a trend.

5 years

Barclays' Africa headquarters spent in Dubai before returning to Johannesburg (2006 to 2011)

91

offices in 54 countries in CMA CGM's African network, which gained its first Africa regional office in Abidjan in 2026

DECISION AND FUNCTION

One organisation, several cities: how the Africa job is divided

EXHIBIT 5

The same organisations appear in two or three cities, each holding a different part of the Africa job

Selected cases from the Heirstone Africa HQ Register

ORGANISATION	WHERE THE REGION IS DECIDED	AFRICA-BASED FUNCTIONS OR ENTITIES
GE	Middle East and Africa HQ, Dubai Internet City (2005; 250+ staff)	Africa HQ, Nairobi (reported in 2015)
Nokia	Middle East and Africa HQ, Dubai Internet City (2005)	MEA technical support hub, Egypt (announced April 2026); Morocco entity with CFC status
Vivo Energy	Group company, London (29 markets)	Africa services entity with CFC status, Casablanca
Orange	Group HQ, Paris	"Orange Middle East and Africa Management", CFC status, Casablanca (transfer date not verified)
Deutsche Bank	Africa business hub, DIFC, Dubai (c.2013 to 2014)	Hub set up to serve its South African business and Africa-Gulf flows (as reported then)
Airtel Africa	Group HQ, London	Operations in 14 African countries
Cisco	Global HQ, United States	Morocco entity with CFC status
Prudential	Group HQ, London and Hong Kong	Africa regional HQ, Nairobi (2021), for eight markets including Cameroon, Côte d'Ivoire and Togo
Afreximbank	HQ, Cairo (US$37.3bn of assets and guarantees, end-2023)	Offices in Abidjan, Abuja, Harare, Kampala and Yaoundé; FEDA fund in Kigali
AfDB	HQ, Abidjan (back since 2015; Tunis 2003 to 2013)	Regional offices in Yaoundé, Nairobi, Tunis, Centurion (Pretoria) and Abidjan

Source: GE press release (30 April 2005); BizNews (4 June 2015); Tech Africa (12 October 2005); Enterprise (27 April 2026); CFC member directory (2026); UK Companies House and company websites (Vivo Energy, Airtel Africa, 2026); Afreximbank (2024; offices page, 2026); AfDB regional pages (2026); World Finance; Capital FM (28 October 2021); The New Times (4 December 2025).

Two layers run through the register. The decision layer holds the regional chief executive, the P&L and the senior team, and in the register, for groups whose Africa business is one part of a wider region, it often sits in Dubai or in a European capital. The function layer holds entities with an explicit Africa mandate: Société Générale's Africa technology and services company and Vivo Energy's Africa services company in Casablanca, Nokia's support hub in Egypt, Afreximbank's export fund in Kigali.

Infomineo's review of the Global 500 is the most recent systematic count we found, and it is for 2017. It counted 155 regional and sub-regional headquarters in Dubai overseeing the Middle East or the whole region, against 29 regional headquarters in Johannesburg plus 46 firms overseeing southern Africa from there. On those figures Dubai hosted about 5.3 times as many as Johannesburg, or about 2.1 times counting the southern-Africa entities. Dubai's count includes headquarters that cover only the Middle East, so neither ratio compares like with like. A 2015 report in BizNews said Johannesburg still outnumbered Nairobi ten to one as a multinational headquarters location.

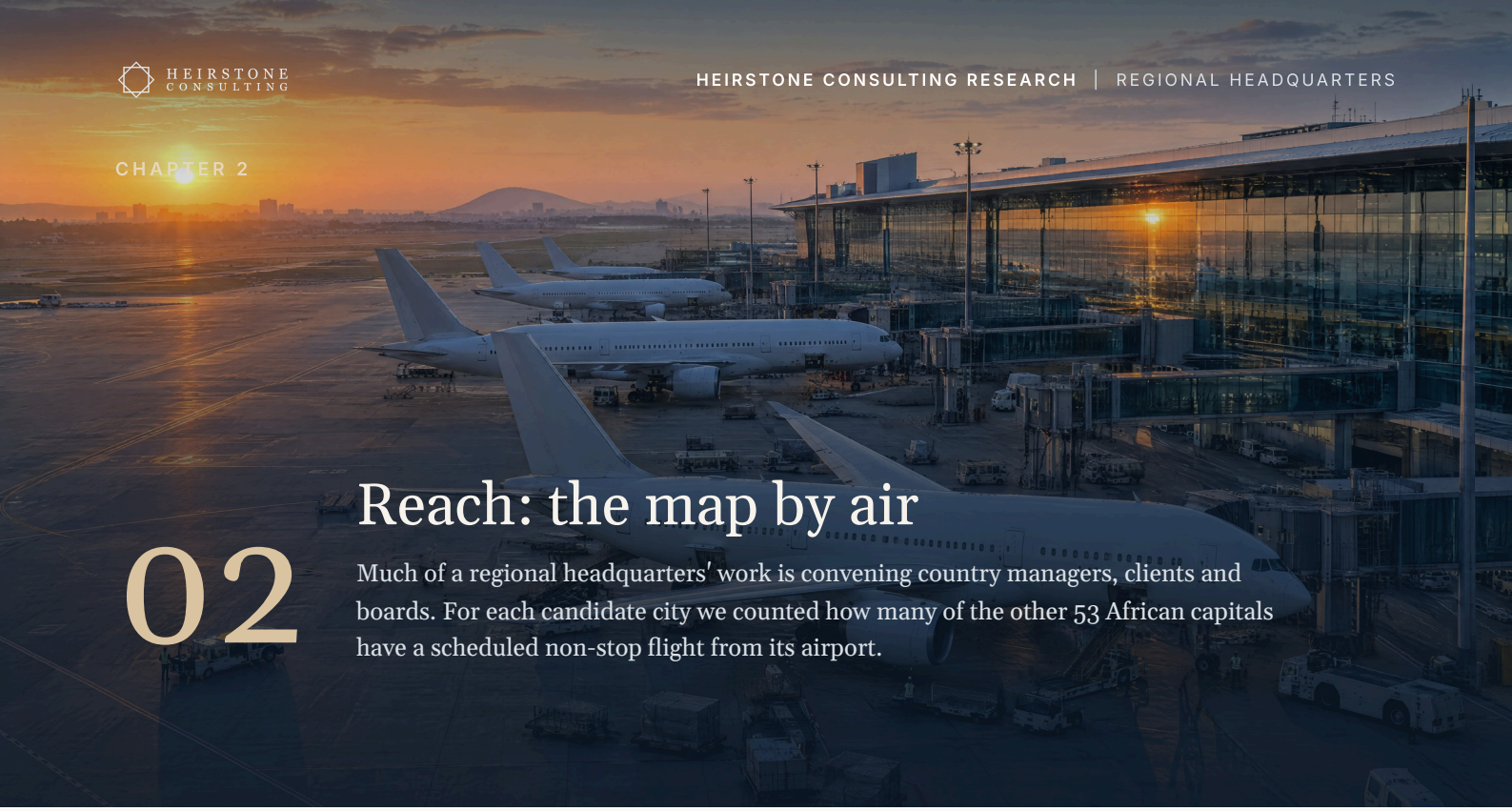
Origin matters. In the same Infomineo review, 15% of Chinese Global 500 firms had a dedicated regional headquarters for the Middle East or Africa, against 49% of US and 55% of Japanese firms.

2.1 to 5.3x

Global 500 regional headquarters in Dubai relative to Johannesburg, 2017, depending on the definition (Infomineo; **Heirstone analysis**)

15%

of Chinese Global 500 firms had a dedicated Middle East or Africa headquarters, against 49% of US firms (2017)



CHAPTER 2

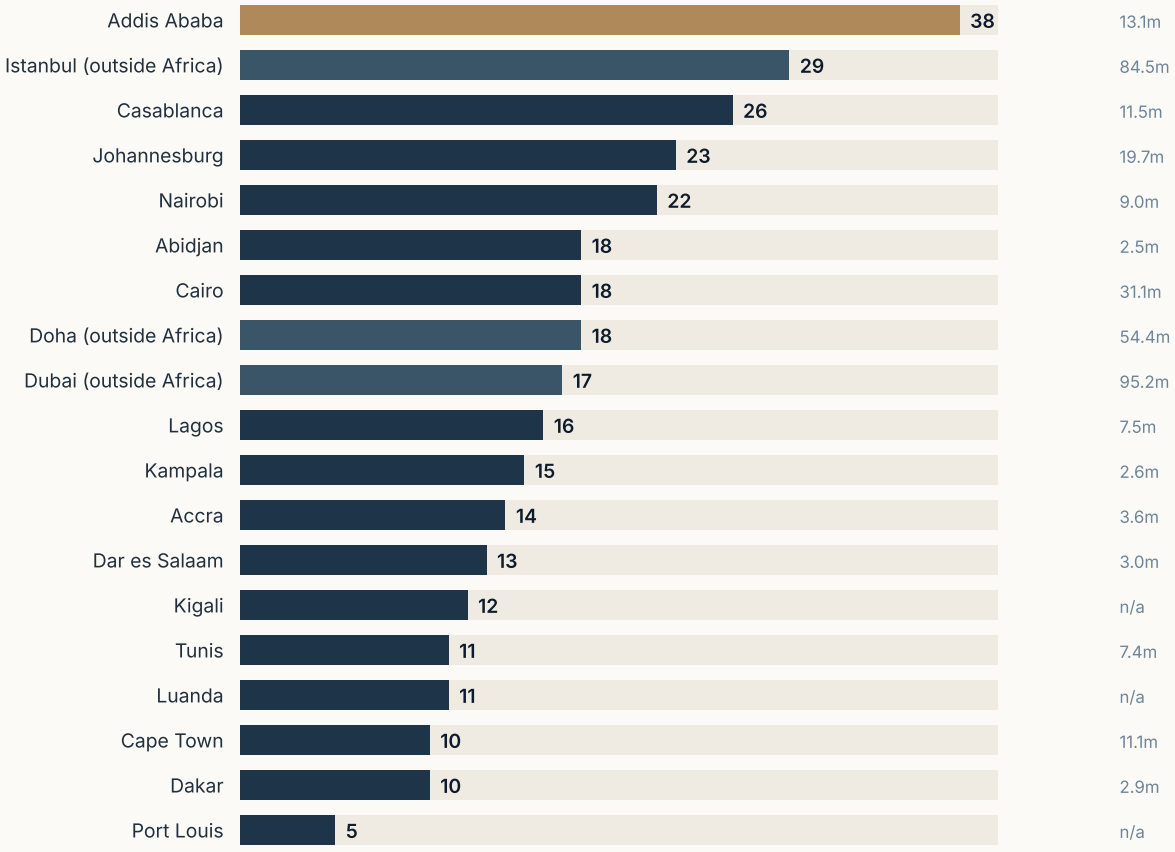
02 Reach: the map by air

Much of a regional headquarters' work is convening country managers, clients and boards. For each candidate city we counted how many of the other 53 African capitals have a scheduled non-stop flight from its airport.

EXHIBIT 6

Addis Ababa reaches 38 African capitals non-stop; Istanbul, outside Africa, is next with 29

African capitals (of 53, own country excluded) with a scheduled non-stop passenger service, 2026 schedules; passengers handled in 2025 at right



Source: FlightConnections airport and route pages, accessed 2026, counted by Heirstone against the African Union capital list (each count about plus or minus 2; Gulf and Istanbul lists may miss tag-on routes). Passengers: France Aviation Civile Services, Air Transport Data Bulletin (2026), provisional; Kigali, Port Louis and Luanda are not listed there. Rabat and Abuja counted at their own airports.

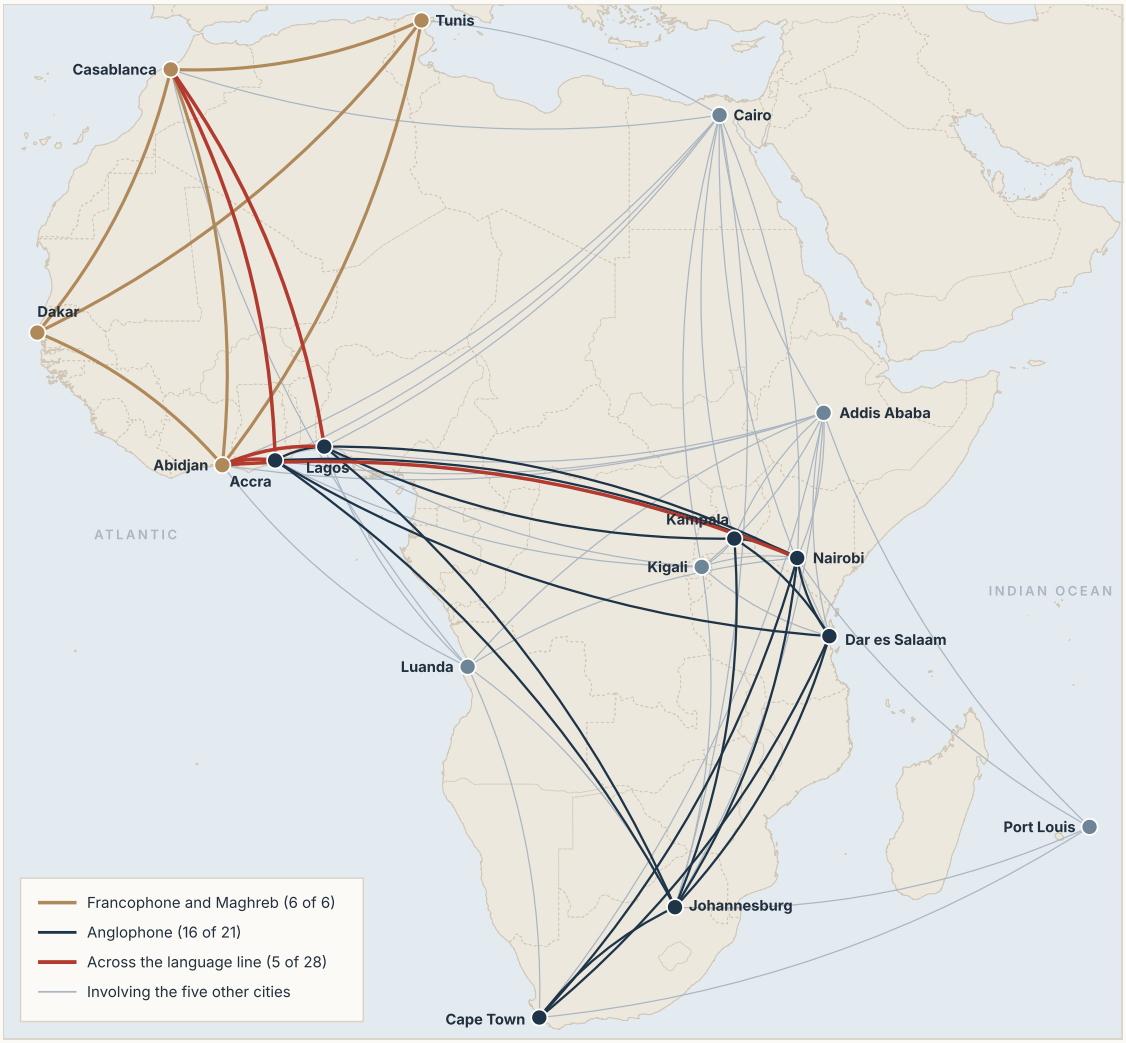
TWO NETWORKS

The francophone and anglophone business cities sit on two air networks that barely touch

EXHIBIT 7

Only 5 of the 28 francophone-anglophone pairs among candidate cities have a non-stop flight

Scheduled non-stop links among 16 candidate cities, either direction, 2026, by language group of the two cities



Source: FlightConnections destination lists and route pages, accessed 2026; pairwise checks by Heirstone. Francophone and Maghreb: Abidjan, Dakar, Casablanca, Tunis. Anglophone: Johannesburg, Cape Town, Nairobi, Lagos, Accra, Dar es Salaam, Kampala. Other: Cairo, Addis Ababa, Kigali, Port Louis, Luanda. Airport positions from GeoNames.

64
of the 120 possible pairs among the 16 candidate cities have a non-stop link (53%)

0
non-stop links from Dakar or Tunis to any of the seven anglophone candidate cities

8h50
fastest trip from Addis Ababa to Dakar, via Abidjan; Nairobi to Dakar takes 8h55

17 of 34
destinations we extracted from Dakar's schedule are in Europe or Istanbul, 7 in France

The five links that cross the language line all run from Abidjan or Casablanca: Abidjan to Lagos, Accra and Nairobi, Casablanca to Lagos and Accra. Casablanca has no non-stop service to Addis Ababa or Nairobi, so its fastest connection to Addis takes 8h35 via Cairo. Cape Town reaches no francophone capital at all.

A pan-African team based in any single city will route many of its trips through Abidjan, Addis Ababa, Cairo or a Gulf hub. Dakar, which reaches 3 of the other 15 candidate cities, is better connected to Europe than to its own continent.

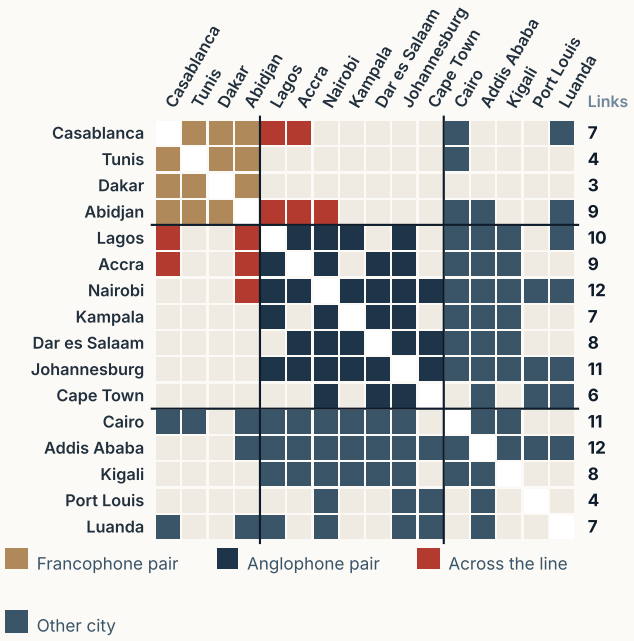
CITY PAIRS AND BLOCS

The best-connected airport for West Africa's trade bloc sits outside it

EXHIBIT 8

Addis Ababa and Nairobi each reach 12 of the other 15 candidate cities; Dakar reaches 3

Scheduled non-stop link between candidate cities, either direction, 2026, grouped by language

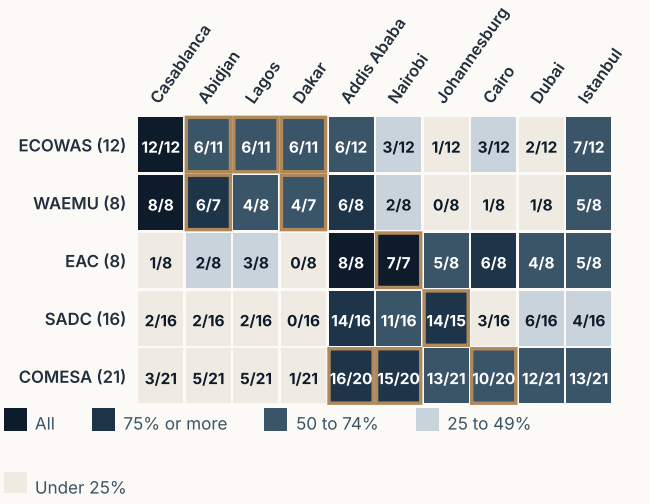


Source: FlightConnections, accessed 2026; Heirstone matrix. Lagos to Dar es Salaam is listed but had no flights in August 2026 and is counted as no link.

EXHIBIT 9

Casablanca reaches all 12 ECOWAS capitals; the four ECOWAS cities we tested reach 6 of 11 each

Capitals of each bloc reached non-stop, own country excluded, 2026; gold outline marks a city inside the bloc



Source: Heirstone analysis of FlightConnections capital lists (2026) against bloc membership: ECOWAS after the January 2025 exits of Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger; EAC with Somalia (2024).

8 of 8

WAEMU capitals reached non-stop from Casablanca, against 6 of 7 from Abidjan and 4 of 7 from Dakar

The matrix shows the francophone block in the top-left corner fully linked, and the anglophone block mostly linked, with an empty band between them. The five cities in neither group do much of the bridging: Cairo reaches 11 of the other 15 candidates and Addis Ababa 12.

Bloc reach gives the sharper test for a sub-regional office. Nairobi and Kampala reach every other EAC capital and Johannesburg 14 of the 15 other SADC capitals. In West Africa the pattern inverts: Casablanca reaches every ECOWAS and WAEMU capital, while Lagos, Accra, Abidjan and Dakar each reach about half of their neighbours. Addis Ababa reaches all 8 EAC capitals and 14 of 16 in SADC without belonging to either.

For a sub-regional office the airport evidence therefore points to different cities in each bloc: Nairobi for the EAC, Johannesburg for SADC, and for francophone West Africa a choice between Casablanca, which has the reach, and Abidjan, which sits inside the currency union and reaches 6 of the 7 other WAEMU capitals.

> *Each of the four West African airports we tested reaches 6 of the other 11 ECOWAS capitals. Casablanca reaches all twelve.*

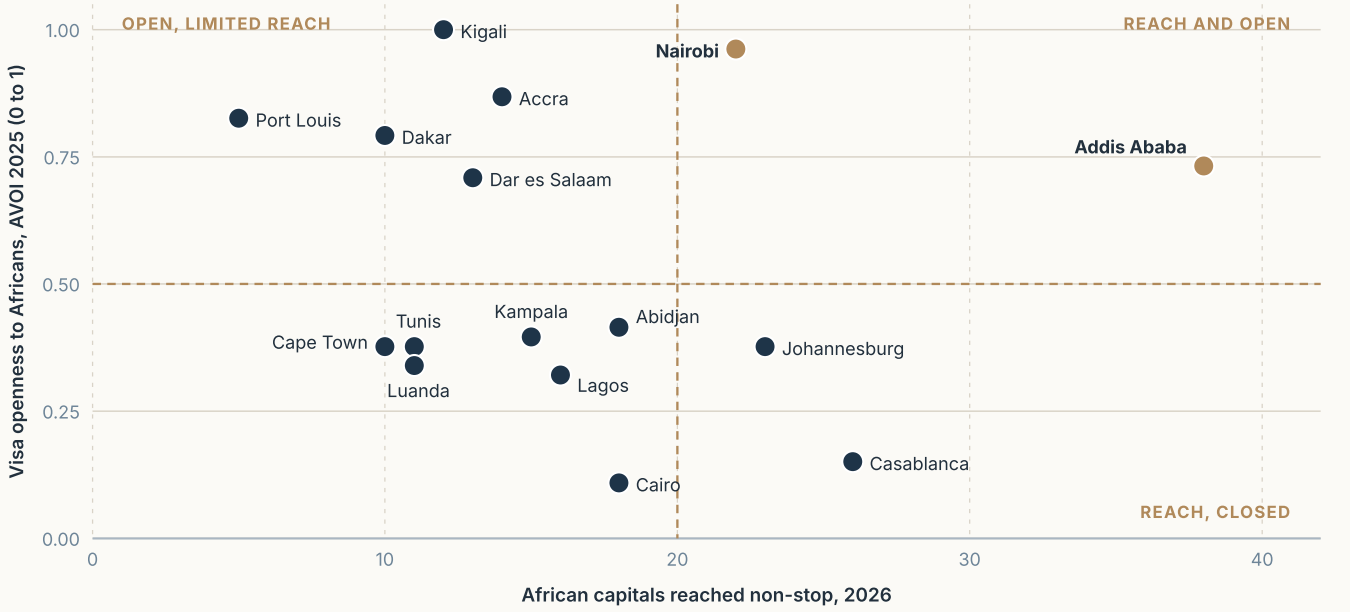
VISAS AND AIRLINES

Visa rules decide whether a well-connected city can convene the region

EXHIBIT 10

Only Addis Ababa and Nairobi combine non-stop reach to 20 or more capitals with visa openness above 0.5

African capitals reached non-stop (2026) against the host country's Africa Visa Openness Index score (2025)



Source: FlightConnections (accessed 2026), Heirstone count; African Development Bank and African Union, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025. Thresholds of 20 capitals and 0.5 are Heirstone choices. Dubai not shown: the index covers African countries only.

Under the Africa Visa Openness Index, Africans need no visa in 28% of intra-African country-to-country travel scenarios, and only The Gambia and Rwanda admit all African nationals visa-free; 31 countries offer Africans an e-Visa. A headquarters that convenes regional teams, clients and boards needs both the flights and the visas.

Two of the best-connected cities sit lower on the index, which measures entry for African nationals: Morocco scores 0.151 and Egypt 0.109. Rwanda is fully open at 1.000 but Kigali reaches only 12 capitals, and the new Bugesera airport is expected to open in 2028, according to RwandAir's chief executive.

Each hub's reach also depends on one carrier. Ethiopian Airlines flies 97% of the destinations from Addis Ababa, Royal Air Maroc 88% of Casablanca's, Turkish Airlines 87% of Istanbul's and EgyptAir 70% of Cairo's. Lagos (29%) and Accra (19%) have no dominant home carrier. Ethiopia began building the US$12.5bn Bishoftu airport, designed around Ethiopian Airlines' transfer traffic, in January 2026, with a first opening targeted for 2030.

Istanbul is the strongest outside competitor on this measure. It reaches 29 African capitals non-stop, against 17 from Dubai and 18 from Doha, which suggests that Dubai's appeal as an Africa base rests on factors other than African reach. Chapters 3 and 4 measure those.

97%

of non-stop destinations from Addis Ababa are flown by Ethiopian Airlines

29 vs 17

African capitals reached non-stop from Istanbul and from Dubai

31.1m

passengers at Cairo in 2025, up 7.5% on 2024: Africa's busiest airport, with non-stop links to 18 African capitals and 11 of the other 15 candidate cities

CHAPTER 3

03 Cost: schools before rent

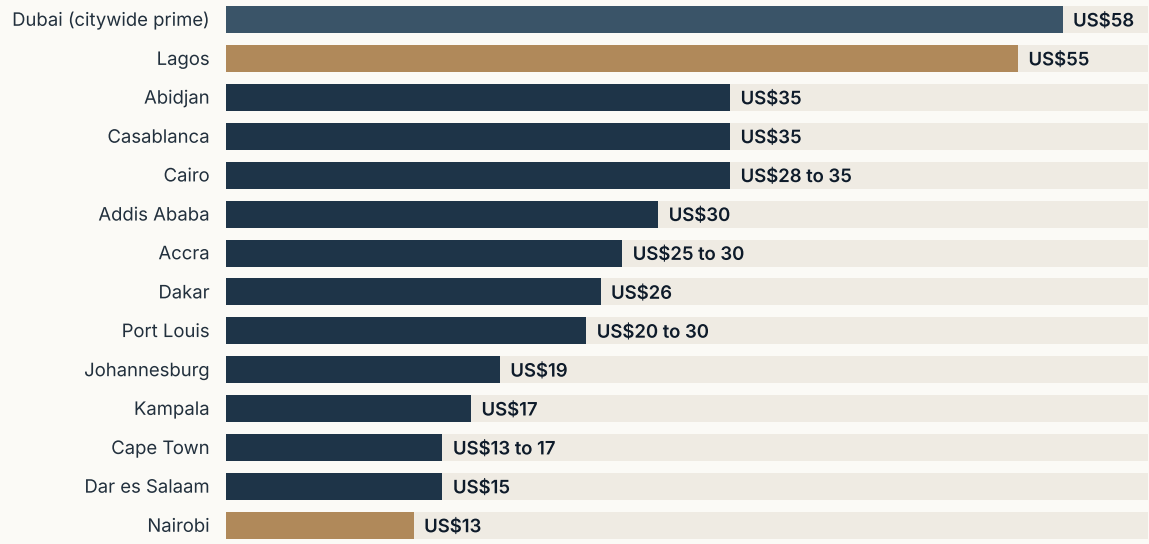
Prime office rent is where most headquarters comparisons begin. For a regional headquarters it is a minor line. The floor area is small, and the cost sits with the expatriate families who staff it: their housing, their children's schools and the allowances that persuade them to move.

This chapter starts with rent, because the spread is wide, and then builds the full location cost of a 50-person headquarters in each city. Rents are in US dollars, as Knight Frank publishes them; local-currency figures are converted at 2026 rates.

EXHIBIT 11

Lagos and Dubai have the dearest prime offices; Nairobi's cost about a quarter as much

Prime office rent, US$ per sq m per month, 2026; bars at the published figure or the top of a published range



Source: Knight Frank, Africa Office Market Dashboard H1 2026 and The Africa Report 2026/27; Dubai from a K Estates release on Zawya citing several brokers (AED 238 per sq ft a year, grade C). Cairo: Knight Frank's dashboard says US$28 and its Africa Report US$35; we use US$35. South African figure is the national P-grade range. Kigali, Tunis and Luanda not published.

Knight Frank quotes rents in dollars, which hides currency moves. Lagos prime rent fell from US$67 in 2017 to US$55 by H2 2024 and has held there since, while the naira lost about 85% of its US$ value between end-2015 and 2026. Dollar-quoted rents in a devaluing market move slowly, but Lagos shows that they can fall. Luanda, the dearest African market in 2017 at US$80, has no current comparable.

Supply is moving. Nairobi's Grade A occupancy rose from about 82% to 85% in the first half of 2026, with rent unchanged at KES 1,684 (US$13). Dar es Salaam ran 20% vacancy. Cairo has about 818,000 sq m of new offices due by 2029, mainly in New Cairo and Sheikh Zayed. In Dubai, a broker release put prime rents up 14% in a year, with DIFC, One Central and Downtown effectively full.

US$131

per sq m a month for prime space in DIFC, Dubai (AED 537 per sq ft a year, K Estates, grade C)

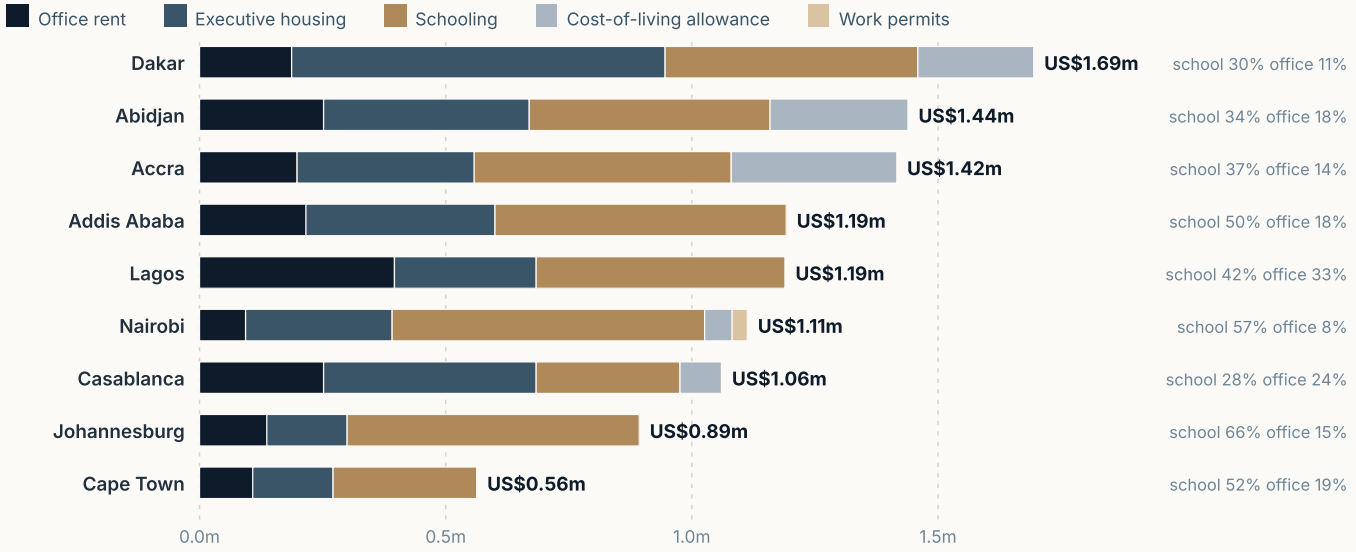
THE COST OF A HEADQUARTERS

On our assumptions, the same headquarters costs three times as much in Dakar as in Cape Town

EXHIBIT 12

Schooling is the largest location cost of an Africa headquarters in seven of the nine cities with complete data

Annual location-sensitive cost of a 50-person headquarters with eight expatriate families, US$, 2026 inputs; local payroll excluded



Source: Heirstone analysis. Inputs: Knight Frank (H1 2026 dashboard; Africa Report 2026/27); school fee schedules for 2026-27 (Casablanca 2025-26; Lagos from an aggregator, grade C); US State Department post allowances, 2026; Kenya State Department for Immigration fees (April 2024), the only work-permit cost we could verify; exchange rates of 2026. Cairo and Port Louis (school fee only), Kigali, Tunis, Luanda, Dar es Salaam, Kampala and Dubai lack inputs and are not ranked.

How the model works. Fifty staff at 12 sq m each take 600 sq m at the city's prime rent. Eight are expatriate assignees, each with one primary and one secondary-school child at a named international school; entry fees are spread over a three-year posting and recurring capital fees added each year. Housing is Knight Frank's prime executive rent: a four-bedroom villa in Dakar but a three-bedroom apartment in South Africa, which flatters Cape Town and Johannesburg. Dakar's schooling uses the top of the school's fee range, so its total is an upper bound. The cost-of-living allowance applies the US post allowance to an assumed US$70,000 of spendable income. Local payroll is left out.

Office rent is 8 to 33% of the total and schooling 28 to 66%. Nairobi has the cheapest prime offices, US$13 per sq m a month, but the International School of Kenya's fees (US$32,540 to 37,330 a year, a US$11,000 entry levy and US$1,600 a year after that) make schooling 57% of its bill. Cape Town is cheapest because its American school bills in rand (R296,142, about US$17,777, for the final grades, plus a R50,000 capital fee each year) and rents are low.

A hardship premium, at the State Department differential on an assumed US$180,000 base, would raise Dakar to about US$2.05m and Cape Town to US$0.78m. Nigeria's paused expatriate levy would add US$80,000 to 120,000 a year if reinstated. At US$28, Cairo's office line would be US$50,400 lower.

US$33,888

location cost per head in Dakar, against US$11,261 in Cape Town

US$7,900

a month for a four-bedroom villa in Les Almadies, Dakar, the highest executive rent among candidate cities

57%

of Nairobi's headquarters location cost goes on schooling

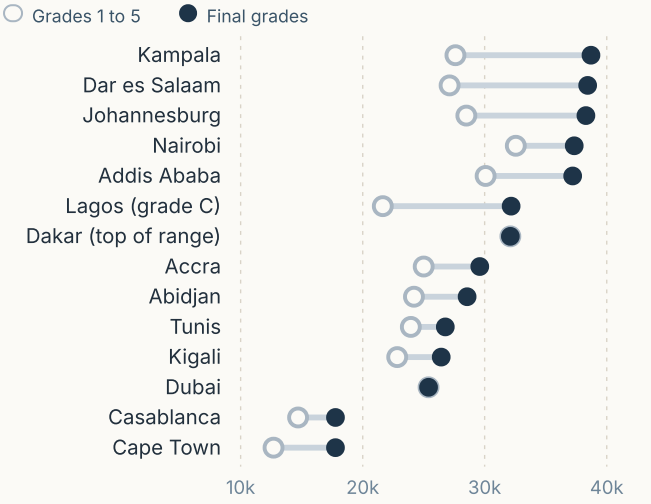
SCHOOLS AND ALLOWANCES

Final-grade school fees sit between US$26,000 and US$39,000 in 11 of 13 African cities

EXHIBIT 13

Only schools that bill in rand or dirham fall below US$18,000 for the final grades

Annual tuition at a named US-curriculum or international school, US$, 2026-27

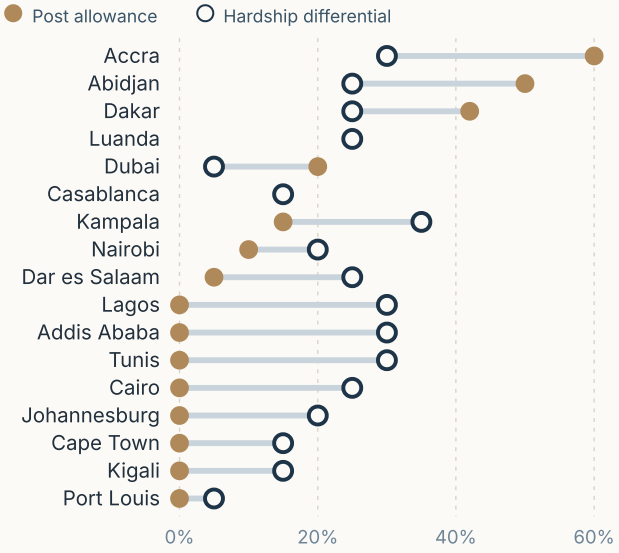


Source: School fee schedules (accessed 2026): ISU, IST, AISJ, ISK, ICS Addis, AIS Lagos (via doris.school, grade C), ISD, Lincoln, ICSA, ACST, ISK Kigali, GEMS Dubai American Academy, CAS (2025-26 corporate rate), AISCT. Local fees converted at 2026 rates.

EXHIBIT 14

The US cost-of-living allowance is 42 to 60% in Accra, Abidjan and Dakar and zero in Lagos and Cairo

US State Department post (cost-of-living) allowance and hardship differential, % of pay, rates effective 2026



Source: US Department of State, Office of Allowances, post allowance and hardship differential tables, 2026.

Fees for the final grades at the named international school sit between about US$26,000 and US$39,000 in 11 of the 13 African cities we checked, whether the local economy is large or small. The two exceptions bill in local currency: Casablanca American School charges MAD 176,292 (about US$17,772) for grades 9 to 12 at its corporate rate, and the American International School of Cape Town R296,142. Dubai's GEMS Dubai American Academy, at AED 93,300 (about US$25,405) for every grade, is cheaper than the leading schools in Nairobi, Addis Ababa or Kampala.

Allowances follow living costs, which can diverge from office rents. Lagos has the dearest prime offices among the markets Knight Frank tracks, yet Mercer ranked it 225th of 226 cities for expatriate living costs in 2024 and Abuja 226th, after the naira's fall; in 2019 Lagos had ranked 25th of 209. The US post allowance for Lagos, Cairo, Addis Ababa, Johannesburg and Kigali is 0%, against 60% in Accra and 50% in Abidjan. Dubai ranked 15th in Mercer's survey, dearer than any African candidate, but its 5% hardship rating matches only Mauritius among them.

At an assumed US$180,000 base, the State Department scale implies a hardship premium of US$72,000 a year for eight assignees in Port Louis or Dubai and US$504,000 in Kampala, more than the office rent of a 50-person headquarters in any African candidate.

225th

Lagos in Mercer's 2024 cost-of-living ranking of 226 cities, down from 25th of 209 in 2019

5%

hardship differential for Dubai and Mauritius, against 15 to 35% for the other candidates

TAX AND PERMITS

Corporate tax rates run from 0% to 35%. For the largest groups a 15% minimum narrows the contest.

EXHIBIT 15

Rwanda, Mauritius and the UAE compete on headline rates; Kenya's new centre rate sits at exactly 15%

Corporate income tax and headquarters or financial-centre regimes relevant to an Africa regional headquarters, 2026

JURISDICTION	HEADLINE CIT	HEADQUARTERS OR FINANCIAL-CENTRE REGIME	TOP PERSONAL RATE
Rwanda	28%	0% for qualifying regional offices of international companies; 3% for holding companies and investment vehicles; KIFC: 0% withholding tax on dividends, interest and royalties	30%
Mauritius	15%	80% partial exemption on specified foreign income (about 3% effective); 2% CSR levy; 5% Fair Share Contribution above MUR 24m (about US$0.5m) until June 2028	20%
UAE	9%	0% up to AED 375,000; 0% on qualifying income of Qualifying Free Zone Persons; 15% domestic minimum top-up tax for groups with revenue of EUR 750m or more, from 2025	none
Kenya	30%	NIFC: 15% for 10 years, then 20% for 10, for firms investing KES 3bn (about US$23.2m) in three years; dividend withholding exemption if KES 250m is reinvested yearly	35%
Morocco	20% / 35%	CFC status: 20% (35% applies at MAD 100m of profit or more); the company must be managed from the CFC with at least one resident manager	37%
South Africa	27%	Section 9I headquarter company: exempt from CFC rules and dividend withholding tax; 80% of assets must be foreign shares, loans or IP	45%
Nigeria	30% + 4%	4% development levy for large companies; 15% minimum effective rate for turnover of NGN 50bn (about US$37.6m) or groups of EUR 750m	25%
Egypt	22.5%	Free-zone entities exempt on licensed activities (PwC lists no separate headquarters regime)	27.5%
Eight others	20 to 30%	Ghana, Côte d'Ivoire, Senegal, Ethiopia, Tunisia, Angola, Tanzania, Uganda: no headquarters-specific regime identified	25 to 43%

Source: PwC Worldwide Tax Summaries (corporate and personal rate charts accessed 2026; country pages reviewed January to September 2026); Kigali International Financial Centre; Cliffe Dekker Hofmeyr (25 September 2025); CFC Authority. Rwanda's qualifying conditions for the 0% rate were not verified. Local amounts at 2026 rates.

Low rates matter most for the entities that book income: holding companies, treasury centres, fund vehicles. For large groups the gap is closing. The UAE applies a 15% domestic minimum top-up tax to groups with revenue of EUR 750m or more from 2025, and Nigeria's new tax act sets a 15% minimum effective rate for the same groups. Under the global minimum tax rules, Rwanda's 0%, Mauritius's effective 3% and the UAE free-zone 0% can therefore be topped up to 15% for those groups, and Kenya's NIFC rate is set at 15%. For smaller groups and for funds, the headline gaps still apply.

Work-permit costs are small beside schooling and housing, but several have changed recently. Kenya raised its Class D work permit from KES 200,000 to KES 500,000 a year (about US$3,860) in April 2024. Nigeria announced an expatriate employment levy of US$15,000 per director and US$10,000 per other expatriate in early 2024, then paused it for consultation; no repeal has been reported. Mauritius cut the minimum salary for an Occupation Permit to MUR 22,500 a month (about US$470) in July 2024 and added a ten-year Expert Occupation Permit.

15%

minimum effective rate for groups with revenue of EUR 750m or more in the UAE and Nigeria

2.5x

rise in Kenya's Class D work permit fee in April 2024, to KES 500,000 a year



CHAPTER 4

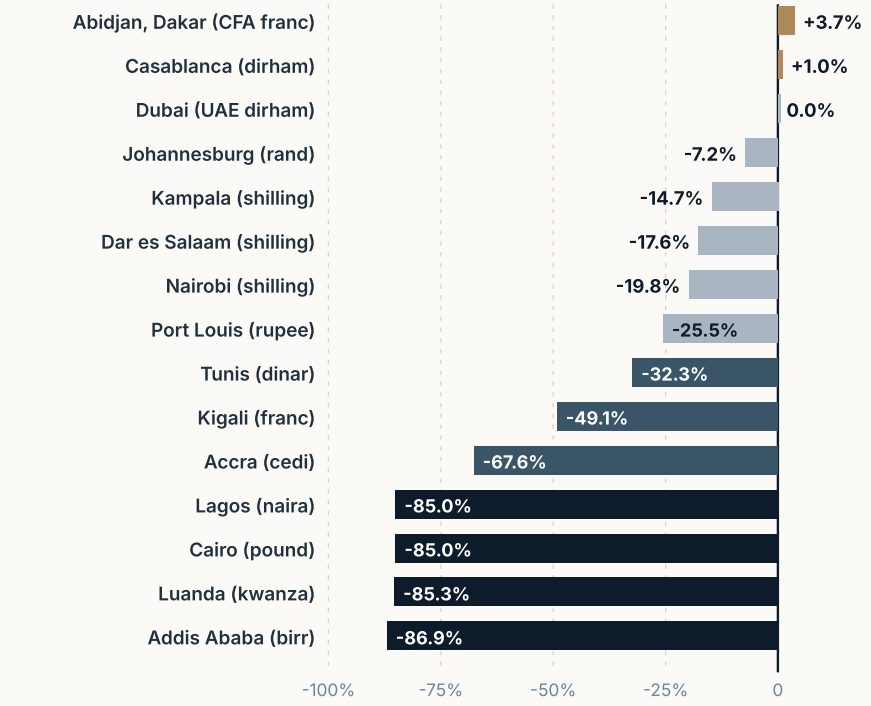
04 Currency: where the cash sits

A regional headquarters often holds the region's cash, signs its contracts and pays its expatriates. Since end-2015 the candidate host countries have split into three currency groups.

EXHIBIT 16

The CFA franc and the dirham gained against the US$; the largest moves came through dated devaluations and floats

Change in the US$ value of the local currency, 31 December 2015 to 2026



Source: Exchange-Rates.org daily history (grade C), cross-checked with IMF representative rates for the rand, rupee, dinar and UAE dirham and World Bank annual averages for the naira, pound, birr and kwanza. Breaks dated with US Treasury reporting rates of exchange; dirham basket from Morocco's Ministry of Economy and Finance (2015) and Hespress (2024). **Heirstone analysis**: (LCU per US$ at end-2015 / LCU per US$ on 2026) minus 1.

Four currencies fell through dated breaks: the naira in mid-2016, mid-2023 and early 2024; the Egyptian pound in November 2016, through 2022 and 2023, and in a March 2024 float that followed the US$35bn Ras El Hekma investment agreement of February 2024; the kwanza by about 39% in the second quarter of 2023; the birr from about 57 per US$ in mid-2024 to 120 three months later. The CFA franc is fixed at 655.957 per euro and the dirham is pegged to a 60:40 euro and dollar basket within a 5% band.

A middle group lost between about 15% and 68%: the cedi 67.6%, the Rwandan franc 49.1%, the Tunisian dinar 32.3%, the Mauritian rupee 25.5% and the three East African shillings about 15 to 20%. The rand lost 7.2%.

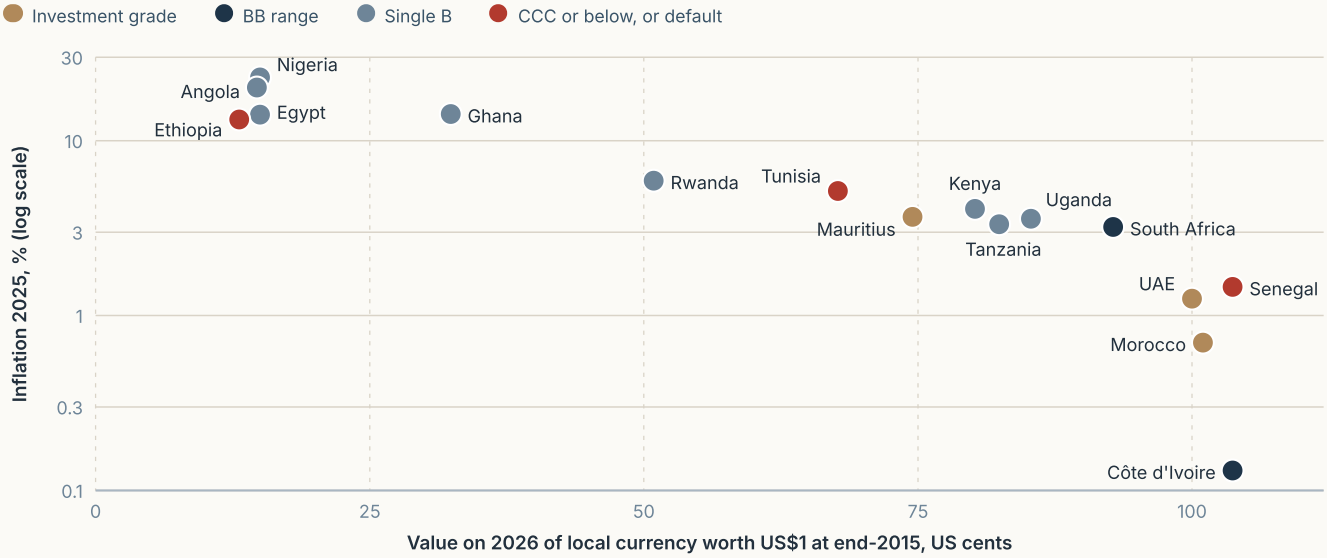
MARKETS AND MONEY

The biggest markets and the steadiest currencies are in different places

EXHIBIT 17

The currencies that held their value also had the lowest inflation and, Senegal apart, the best ratings

Value retained since end-2015 against 2025 consumer price inflation, coloured by long-term foreign-currency rating, 2026

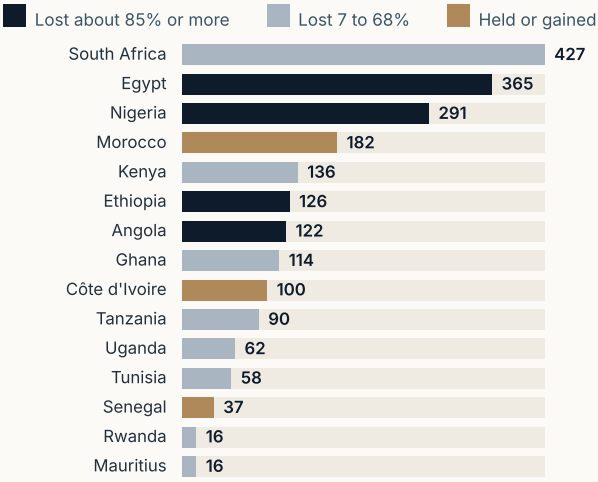


Source: Exchange rates as Exhibit 16; World Bank WDI inflation (updated 13 July 2026); S&P ratings as listed by Trading Economics (2026); Moody's equivalent where S&P lists no rating (Mauritius Baa3, Tunisia Caa1, Tanzania B1). Côte d'Ivoire and Senegal share the CFA franc.

EXHIBIT 18

Egypt is the second-largest host economy after South Africa; the steadiest currencies belong to smaller economies

Host-country GDP, US$bn, 2025, by currency group since end-2015



Source: World Bank WDI, GDP in current US$ (updated 2026): South Africa US$427.2bn, Egypt US$365.3bn, Nigeria US$290.8bn.

Translated into a budget, a local-currency cost base or cash reserve worth US$1m at end-2015 is now worth about US$131,000 to 150,000 in the four markets with the largest moves, US$802,000 in Nairobi and US$928,000 in Johannesburg, and a little over US$1m in Abidjan, Dakar and Casablanca. The rand's result depends on the base, because end-2015 was already a weak point for it.

The steady currencies are also the low-inflation ones: 0.1% in Côte d'Ivoire in 2025, 0.7% in Morocco and 1.5% in Senegal. Inflation has fallen since 2023 in Egypt (33.9% to 14.1%), Ghana (38.1% to 14.2%) and Ethiopia (30.2% to 13.2%). Only Morocco (S&P BBB-) and Mauritius (Moody's Baa3) are rated investment grade; South Africa and Côte d'Ivoire are at BB, and Ethiopia has been rated SD since December 2023.

All 15 African host countries have ratified the AfCFTA, so treaty membership no longer separates them. For the largest markets, the evidence favours strong local management, with treasury policy set by each host's currency regime and the time since its last published backlog.

GETTING MONEY OUT

Repatriation backlogs come in dated episodes after a currency break, and the largest published ones have been cleared

EXHIBIT 19

Every published backlog outside airline funds has been declared cleared; among candidate hosts, IATA's recent lists name only Angola and Ethiopia

Published episodes in which companies or airlines could not repatriate local-currency earnings, with amounts and status as reported; most recent first, context rows last

COUNTRY	EPISODE	PERIOD	AMOUNT	STATUS AS REPORTED
Angola	Airline funds blocked	Oct 2025; Mar 2026	US$81m; US$73m	Outstanding at those dates
Ethiopia	Airline funds blocked	Oct 2025	US$54m	Outstanding at that date
Nigeria	Foreign-exchange backlog	to 2024	US$7bn	Declared settled by the CBN Governor
Nigeria	Airline funds blocked	Peak June 2023	US$850m	US$831m (98%) cleared by June 2024 (IATA)
Egypt	Import goods held at ports	Mar 2022 to Jan 2023	Not quantified	Declared cleared by the prime minister, January 2023; flexible regime under a US$3bn IMF arrangement
Egypt	Requests pending before the November 2016 float	Nov 2016 to Aug 2017	Multinational requests, foreign-company dividends, shipments in ports and overdraft settlements	Cleared, per a central bank official (Bloomberg)
Algeria (context)	Airline funds blocked	Oct 2025; Mar 2026	US$307m; US$258m	Largest single country in IATA's list
CEMAC zone (context)	Airline funds blocked	Oct 2025; Mar 2026	US$179m; US$105m	Outstanding at those dates

Source: Bloomberg via BloombergQuint (2017) and BNN Bloomberg (January 2023); Financial Edge (Nigeria), CBN Governor's remarks (2024); The Gazette (Nigeria) quoting IATA (2 June 2024); IATA press release (10 December 2025); CAPA Centre for Aviation (30 April 2026). IATA data cover airlines only.

IATA's blocked-funds series is the only regular cross-country measure of repatriation, and it covers airlines alone. At end-October 2025, US$1.2bn of airline funds were blocked worldwide, 93% of it in Africa and the Middle East; at 31 March 2026 Angola was the only one of our candidate host countries in IATA's African top list.

The Egyptian and Nigerian episodes followed currency breaks and were cleared once the rate moved. A more useful measure for a headquarters treasury than a static risk label is the time since the last published backlog: Egypt cleared backlogs in 2017 and 2023 and floated in March 2024; Nigeria's central bank governor said in 2024 that its US$7bn backlog had been settled.

The best-known corporate pull-backs concern how a market is served. In Nigeria, P&G ended local manufacturing in December 2023, its finance chief saying it was very difficult to create value there as a US dollar-denominated company; GSK and Sanofi moved to distributors in 2023 and Kimberly-Clark exited in May 2024. Africa Check found that GSK, P&G and Sanofi had changed model, not left. The one regional function among them is Microsoft's Africa Development Centre in Lagos, opened in 2022 and closed in May 2024.

US$46.58bn

net FDI inflows to Egypt in 2024, the year of the Ras El Hekma agreement and the March float, against US$9.84bn in 2023 (World Bank)

98%

of Nigeria's blocked airline funds cleared between the June 2023 peak and June 2024

CHAPTER 5

05 The Heirstone Africa HQ Index and five roles

The index brings the four tests into one score for 16 African cities, with Dubai scored on the same scale as a benchmark and not ranked. It is built only from the public inputs in chapters 2 to 4.

Each indicator is rescaled from 0 to 100 across the 16 African cities, so 100 is the best African value and 0 the weakest; Dubai is scored against the same range and capped at 0 and 100. Where a city lacks an indicator, the other indicators in that pillar carry its weight, and the table shows how many of the 11 inputs each city has.

We left tax out. Headline rates matter for some entities but, for groups above EUR 750m, the 15% minimum taxes described in chapter 3 narrow the differences, and the regimes are too specific to score on one line.

METHOD

Four pillars, eleven indicators

PILLAR	WEIGHT	INDICATORS (WEIGHT WITHIN INDEX)	FROM 0 TO 100 ACROSS THE 16	SOURCES
Reach	30	African capitals reached non-stop (20) Africa Visa Openness Index score (10)	5 to 38 capitals 0.109 to 1.000	FlightConnections, 2026; AfDB and AU, AVOI 2025
Cost	25	Schooling per expatriate family (8) Expatriate premium per assignee (7) Prime office rent (5) Prime executive housing rent (5)	US$79,337 to 36,483 a year US$96,000 to 9,000 a year US$55 to 13 per sq m a month US$7,900 to 1,700 a month	Knight Frank 2026; school fee schedules 2026-27; US State Department, 2026
Stability	25	Change in US$ value of currency since end-2015 (10) Sovereign rating (10) Consumer price inflation, 2025 (5)	-86.9% to +3.7% SD to BBB- 23.0% to 0.1%	Exchange-Rates.org, IMF, World Bank WDI; S&P via Trading Economics (Moody's where S&P does not rate)
Talent and depth	20	Tertiary enrolment ratio (10) Host-country GDP, 2025 (log) (10)	4.0% to 48.2% US$16bn to 427bn	World Bank WDI and UNESCO UIS

Scoring. Higher is better: costs, inflation and the expatriate premium are inverted. Capitals reached, visa openness, the change in currency value, tertiary enrolment and GDP (on a log scale) are scored as published. Ratings are converted to a notch scale (SD 0, CC 2, CCC+ 3, B- 4, B 5, B+ 6, BB 8, BBB- 10, AA 18). The expatriate premium per assignee combines the post allowance on US$70,000 and the hardship differential on US$180,000. Cairo's office rent is taken at US$35, the higher of Knight Frank's two figures. Tertiary enrolment is the latest World Bank value, which dates from 2011 for Nigeria and 2014 for Ethiopia and Uganda.

Weights. The base weights favour reach, because a regional headquarters that cannot gather its region fails at its main task. To test how much the ranking depends on that choice, we re-ran the index under three other schemes: a command weighting (stability 35, cost 25, reach 20, talent 20), a convening weighting (reach 45, cost 20, stability 15, talent 20) and a service-centre weighting (talent 35, cost 30, stability 20, reach 15). The rank range across all four is shown in the index table. Casablanca also ranks first with equal weights and in 5,000 re-runs that move each capital count at random by up to two either way.

FOUR PILLARS, FOUR DIFFERENT LEADERS

90
Reach: Addis Ababa
weakest: Cape Town (20)

93
Cost: Cape Town
weakest: Dakar (32)

98
Stability: Casablanca
weakest: Addis Ababa (9)

87
Talent and depth: Casablanca
weakest: Kigali (6)

THE HEIRSTONE AFRICA HQ INDEX 2026

Casablanca leads under every weighting we tested. Addis Ababa's rank moves the most.

EXHIBIT 20

Casablanca scores 73; the cheapest and steadiest southern cities follow, and the best-connected city ranks 10th

Pillar scores (0 to 100) and index score, base weights; rank range across four weighting schemes; 16 African cities and Dubai as benchmark, 2026

RANK	CITY	REACH (30)	COST (25)	STABILITY (25)	TALENT AND DEPTH (20)	INDEX	RANK RANGE	INPUTS
1	Casablanca	44	71	98	87	**73.0**	1	11/11
	Dubai (benchmark)	36	56	97	100	**69.3**	n/a	8/11
2	Cape Town	20	93	84	72	**64.9**	2 to 5	11/11
3	Johannesburg	46	60	84	72	**64.5**	2 to 3	11/11
4	Port Louis	27	85	84	47	**59.9**	4 to 6	10/11
5	Nairobi	66	53	66	40	**57.5**	3 to 6	11/11
6	Abidjan	38	40	92	37	**51.7**	6 to 7	11/11
7	Dar es Salaam	39	54	72	26	**48.2**	7 to 10	10/11
8	Cairo	26	61	29	86	**47.6**	5 to 8	10/11
9	Kigali	47	68	56	6	**46.5**	9 to 11	9/11
10	Addis Ababa	90	42	9	34	**46.3**	4 to 14	11/11
11	Tunis	22	50	52	58	**43.7**	8 to 12	9/11
12	Accra	47	37	32	49	**41.2**	10 to 13	11/11
13	Dakar	36	32	67	25	**40.5**	11 to 14	11/11
14	Kampala	31	36	65	21	**38.7**	12 to 15	10/11
15	Lagos	30	41	21	51	**34.7**	13 to 15	11/11
16	Luanda *	21	39	19	38	**28.2**	16	8/11

Source: Heirstone analysis; inputs and sources on the previous page. Pillar scores of 80 or more in gold. * Luanda is provisional: its cost pillar rests on one input. Dubai is scored on the African scale but not ranked; it lacks visa-openness, housing and GDP inputs in our data.

Casablanca ranks first under all four weightings. It combines an investment-grade rating, a dirham that held its value, inflation of 0.7%, a tertiary enrolment ratio of 48% and the second-widest reach of any African airport. Its weak points are visa openness (0.151) and an air network that faces west and south: 6 of 22 anglophone capitals.

Cape Town and Johannesburg follow on cost and stability; Port Louis ranks fourth although it reaches the fewest capitals. Cairo is second on talent and depth (86) and ranks 5th to 8th. Addis Ababa scores highest on reach (90) and lowest on stability (9), so its rank runs from 4th under the convening weights to 14th under the command weights. Dubai, scored on the African scale and on fewer inputs, would sit second.

An average of this kind lets a strength in one pillar make up for a failure in another. Port Louis reaches five capitals; Cape Town reaches ten and no francophone one. Neither would work as a gateway for the whole continent, whatever its score. The next two pages therefore turn the scores into pass-or-fail gates for each role a headquarters plays.

98

Casablanca's stability score, the highest in Africa; Addis Ababa scores 9

4 to 14

Addis Ababa's rank range across the four weighting schemes, the widest in the index

86

Cairo's talent and depth score, second only to Casablanca among the 16 African cities

A HEIRSTONE FRAMEWORK

Five roles a headquarters city can play, each with its own gate

The Africa job breaks into five roles. Each has a gate set from the data in this report: a minimum a city must clear, which a strong score elsewhere cannot offset. Thresholds are Heirstone choices and are stated so that readers can move them.

1 Command seat

Holds: Regional chief executive, P&L, expatriate leadership
Gate: Currency kept two-thirds of its 2015 US$ value; sovereign rated BB- or better; tertiary enrolment 20% or more; 10 or more African capitals non-stop

2 Gateway

Holds: Convening, regional travel, client and board meetings
Gate: 20 or more African capitals non-stop; visa openness score 0.5 or more

3 Licence centre

Holds: Holding company, treasury, fund vehicles, legal seat
Gate: Dedicated regime in force with a preferential rate; 100 or more firms, licences or investors reported

4 Service centre

Holds: Shared services, technical support, engineering
Gate: Tertiary enrolment 20% or more; prime office US$35 or less; US post allowance 15% or less

5 Bloc office

Holds: Sub-regional management inside one trade or currency bloc
Gate: Inside the bloc, and reaches 75% or more of the bloc's other capitals non-stop

EXHIBIT 21

No city passes all five gates; Johannesburg, Cape Town and Casablanca pass three each

Gate results by city and role, 2026; filled square = passes; outlined gold = provisional (an input is missing)

CITY	1 COM-MAND	2 GATE-WAY	3 LICENCE	4 SERVICE	5 BLOC	BLOC REACH	PASS
Casablanca	■		■	■			3
Cape Town	■			■	■	SACU 3/4	3
Johannesburg	■			■	■	SADC 14/15, SACU 4/4	3
Port Louis			■	■			2
Nairobi		■			■	EAC 7/7, COMESA 15/20	2
Addis Ababa		■			■	COMESA 16/20	2
Dubai	■		■				2
Abidjan					■	WAEMU 6/7	1
Cairo				■			1
Kigali			■				1
Tunis				▢	■	AMU 4/4	1
Kampala					■	EAC 7/7	1
Dar es Salaam							0
Accra							0
Dakar							0
Lagos							0
Luanda							0

Source: Heirstone analysis of the inputs in chapters 1 to 4. Licence centres: Mauritius (12,918 Global Business Companies), CFC (220 firms), KIFC (300+ investors, interview figure), Dubai free zones; NIFC (28 firms, March 2026) below the threshold. Tunis service result provisional: no published prime rent.

Three cities pass three gates each. Johannesburg and Cape Town pass the command, service and bloc-office gates; Casablanca passes command, licence and service. None of them passes the gateway gate: South Africa and Morocco score 0.377 and 0.151 on visa openness. Only Addis Ababa and Nairobi pass it, and neither passes the command gate, Addis Ababa on currency and rating and Nairobi on rating and tertiary enrolment.

Lagos, Accra, Dakar, Luanda and Dar es Salaam pass no gate, though for some one change would alter that. Dar es Salaam reaches 5 of the 7 other EAC capitals, one short of the bloc threshold; Accra fails the service gate only on its 60% US post allowance. Cape Town clears the command and bloc gates exactly at the threshold (10 capitals; 3 of 4 SACU capitals). Dubai passes the command and licence gates and fails the gateway gate, with 17 African capitals non-stop.

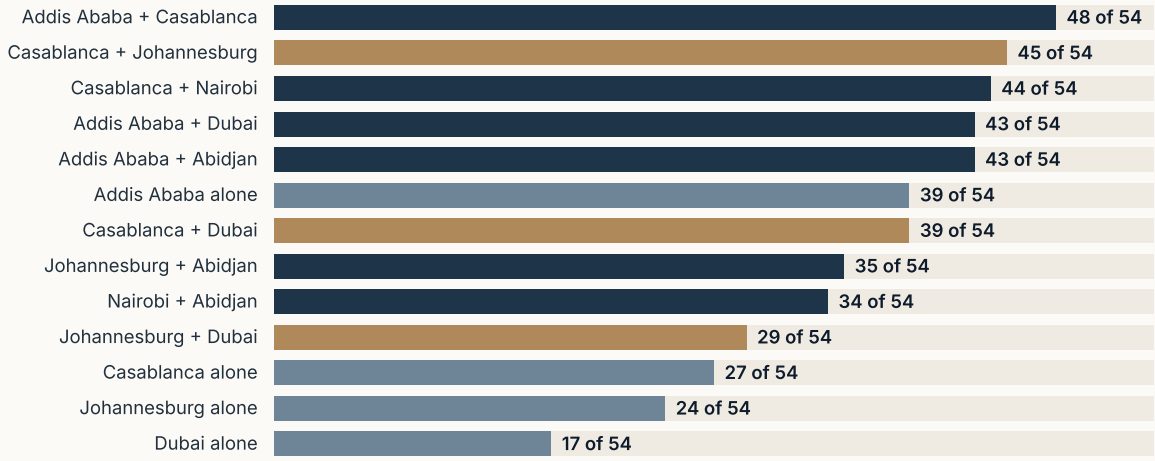
TWO HUBS

A hub on each side of the language line reaches more of Africa than any single city

EXHIBIT 22

A Casablanca and Johannesburg pair reaches 45 of 54 African countries non-stop, more than Addis Ababa alone (39)

African countries whose capital is reached non-stop from at least one city of the pair, counting the hubs' own countries, 2026



Source: Heirstone analysis of FlightConnections capital lists, accessed 2026 (each list about plus or minus 2). Grey bars are single cities; gold marks pairs in which both cities pass the command gate.

Pairing two cities fixes the weakness that most single cities share. Casablanca covers francophone, Sahelian and West Africa; Johannesburg covers the south and east. Together they reach 45 of 54 countries, and both pass the command gate, so leadership can sit in either. Casablanca with Nairobi reaches 44, with Nairobi adding the gateway role and the UN cluster but failing the command gate on its B rating and 10% tertiary enrolment.

Addis Ababa with Casablanca gives the widest reach of any pair, 48 countries, because Ethiopian's network covers the east, centre and south and Royal Air Maroc's the west. Addis Ababa fails the stability gates, so in that pair it convenes and routes travel while cash and leadership sit in Casablanca. A Dubai command seat paired with an Addis Ababa gateway reaches 43; Casablanca with Dubai reaches 39.

The register has examples of such splits. GE set up its Middle East and Africa headquarters in Dubai in 2005 and was reported to run Africa from Nairobi; Nokia added an Egyptian technical hub in 2026 to its Dubai headquarters; Vivo Energy is based in London and has a services entity in Casablanca; the AfDB runs five regional offices from its Abidjan seat.

45 of 54

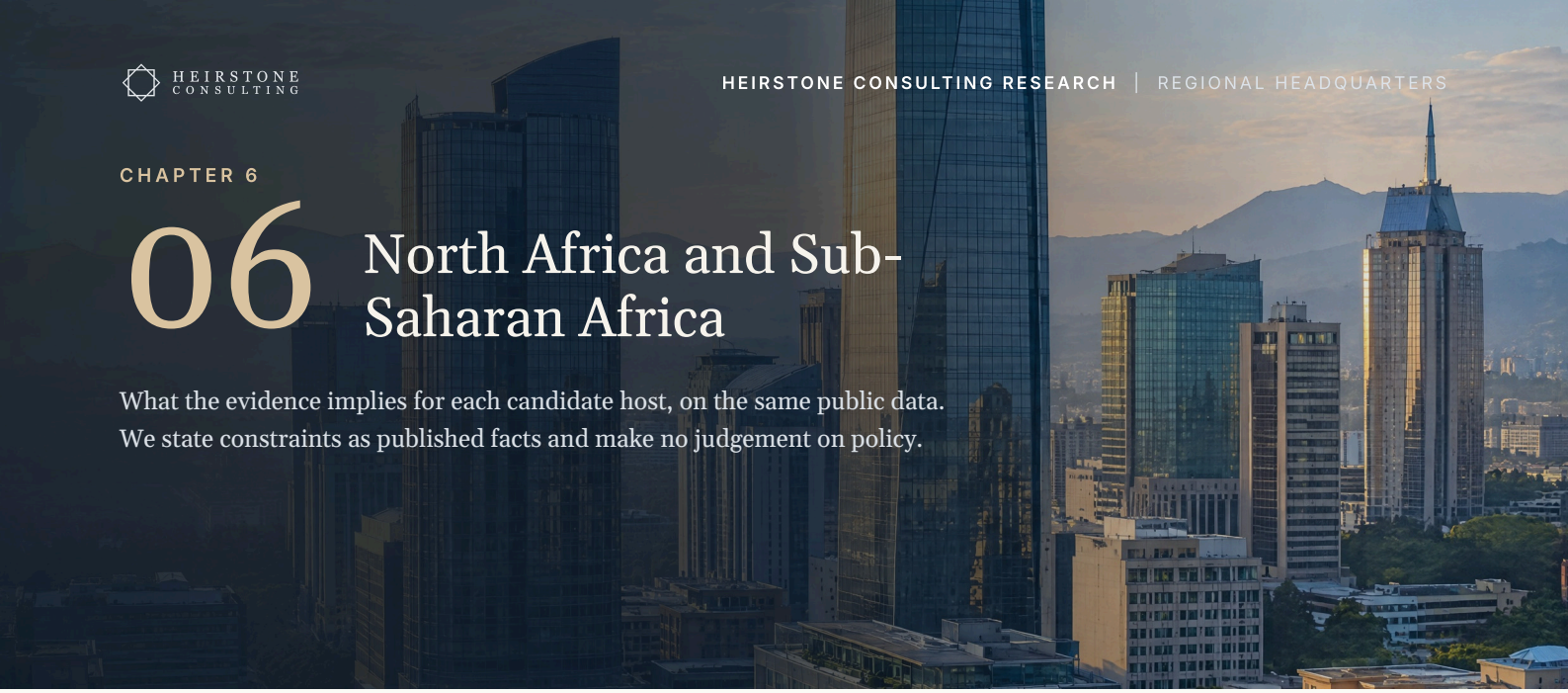
African countries reached non-stop from Casablanca or Johannesburg, both of which pass the command gate

48

countries reached from Addis Ababa or Casablanca, the widest pair

17

countries reached from Dubai alone



CHAPTER 6

06 North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa

What the evidence implies for each candidate host, on the same public data. We state constraints as published facts and make no judgement on policy.

NORTH AFRICA

Morocco. Casablanca is the strongest all-round candidate in our index and the most complete francophone platform. The CFC had about 220 status firms in May 2026, according to Wafir.ma, and 105 of the roughly 270 entities in its directory carry a regional mandate in their name, from Orange Middle East and Africa Management to SAP North West Africa. Its members' African business leans to the francophone south: at end-2021, 51% were active in Côte d'Ivoire, 45% in Senegal and 29% in Cameroon. Casablanca's airport reaches every ECOWAS and WAEMU capital, but only 6 of 22 anglophone capitals and neither Addis Ababa nor Nairobi, and Morocco scores 0.151 on visa openness. For anglophone mandates its natural partner is in the east or south.

Egypt. Cairo is second on talent and depth in our index (86), with a 38% tertiary enrolment ratio and the second-largest host economy. Its recent wins are in trade finance and technical support: Afreximbank is based there, with US$37.3bn of assets and guarantees at end-2023; Nokia chose Egypt for its Middle East and Africa support hub in April 2026; and an EU Neighbours South release reported a new European Investment Bank regional hub in Cairo. The US post allowance is 0%, and the 22.5% corporate tax rate is lower than in 11 of the other 14 African hosts. Egypt floated the pound in March 2024, the year its net FDI inflows reached US$46.58bn. About 818,000 sq m of new offices are due by 2029. The gates to work on are reach (18 capitals) and visa openness (0.109).

Tunisia. Tunis hosted the AfDB from 2003 to 2013 and keeps its North Africa office. Its tertiary enrolment (38%) matches Egypt's and the American Cooperative School charges US$26,765 for the final grades. Its network is Maghreb and Sahel-facing: 11 capitals, none of them anglophone. The dinar has lost 32% of its US$ value since end-2015, and Moody's rates the country Caa1.

Algeria and Libya. Neither is a candidate host in our data. Algeria had the largest blocked airline funds in IATA's lists, US$307m in October 2025 and US$258m in March 2026. Algiers is reached non-stop from seven candidate cities and from Istanbul and Doha.

CASABLANCA

1st
in the Heirstone Africa HQ Index, all four weightings

BBB-
S&P rating, one of two investment-grade African hosts

20%
tax rate for CFC status firms

CAIRO

86
talent and depth score, second of the 16 African cities

31.1m
passengers in 2025, Africa's busiest airport

38%
tertiary enrolment ratio (2025)

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA: EAST AND SOUTHERN AFRICA, AND ANGLOPHONE WEST AFRICA

In the east and south, the gateway, command and licence roles fall to different cities

Kenya. Nairobi has the most named cases in our register outside the CFC directory, 9, and 5 are institutional. UNON, the only UN headquarters office in Africa, says UN agencies are moving some regional and global operations to Kenya. Corporate moves are fewer (Prudential in 2021, Bolt in 2022). Nairobi passes the gateway gate and reaches every other EAC capital, but fails the command gate on its B rating and 10% tertiary enrolment. Its financial centre certified three firms in three years, then 15 on 1 July 2026.

Ethiopia. Addis Ababa is the continent's gateway by a wide margin, with 38 capitals and Africa CDC among its institutions; the US$12.5bn Bishoftu airport is due around 2030. It fails both stability gates: the birr lost 86.9% of its US$ value since end-2015, and S&P has rated Ethiopia SD since December 2023.

South Africa. Johannesburg passes the command, service and bloc-office gates and is home to groups such as MTN, which reports more than 317 million customers in 19 markets. Cape Town has the lowest headquarters cost in our model. Both are limited by visa openness (0.377) and francophone reach: 6 francophone capitals from Johannesburg, none from Cape Town.

Nigeria. Lagos hosts the Africa Finance Corporation and is a market many groups must serve, yet it passes none of our gates: offices at US$55, a naira down 85% and several consumer and pharmaceutical groups moving to import or distributor models in 2023-24.

Ghana. Accra hosts the AfCFTA Secretariat and ranks 5th in Africa on visa openness (0.868), but reaches 14 capitals, carries a 60% US post allowance and saw the cedi lose 67.6% of its US$ value.

Rwanda. Kigali wins seat decisions out of proportion to its size: FIFA's East Africa office, Bboxx's global headquarters and Afreximbank's FEDA. It is fully visa-open, led Sub-Saharan Africa in the World Bank's B-READY 2024 report and offers a 0% corporate tax rate to qualifying regional offices; KIFC has mobilised more than Rwf600bn (about US$406m at 2026 rates). Its limits are 12 capitals and a 9% tertiary enrolment ratio.

Mauritius, Tanzania, Uganda. Mauritius had 12,918 Global Business Companies at end-2023 and an investment-grade rating, and suits licence and holding entities; with 5 capitals it is a weak operating base. Dar es Salaam and Kampala reach 13 and 15 capitals; Kampala's 35% hardship rating is the highest in our set.

NAIROBI

7 of 7
other EAC capitals reached non-stop

0.962
visa openness, 3rd in Africa

JOHANNESBURG

14 of 15
other SADC capitals reached non-stop

3
role gates passed: command, service, bloc

KIGALI

81.3
B-READY 2024 operational efficiency, 3rd globally

300+
investors set up at KIFC since 2021

LAGOS

0
role gates passed

US$55
per sq m a month, the dearest prime offices Knight Frank tracks in Africa

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA: FRANCOPHONE AND LUSOPHONE

Abidjan is gaining regional roles, and Central Africa is mostly reached from hubs outside it

Côte d'Ivoire. Abidjan is the francophone city that has gained most in the recent record. The AfDB moved its headquarters back there from Tunis by 2015; Yango opened a regional office in 2025, calling Côte d'Ivoire its largest and most advanced African market; African Business reported that EBID opened its first regional office there in December 2025; and CMA CGM chose Abidjan for its first Africa regional office in 2026. The CFA franc gained 3.7% against the dollar since end-2015 and inflation was 0.1% in 2025. Abidjan passes the bloc-office gate for WAEMU, reaching 6 of the 7 other capitals, and makes three of the five links that cross the language line. Against that, its headquarters is the second most expensive in our model (about US$1.44m a year), with prime offices at US$35 and a 50% US post allowance, and its tertiary enrolment ratio is 12%.

Senegal. Dakar has the highest headquarters cost in our model, US$1.69m a year, driven by US$7,900 villas and a 42% post allowance; with top-of-range school fees, that figure is an upper bound. Its airport reaches 10 African capitals and 3 of the other 15 candidate cities, with no non-stop link to any anglophone one. Financial Afrik reported in April 2026 that JTI and Colgate-Palmolive had closed factories in Senegal while Abidjan gained regional roles. S&P rates Senegal CC.

Cameroon and Central Africa. No Central African city is in our candidate set. Yaoundé hosts the AfDB's Central Africa hub and an Afreximbank regional office, and 29% of CFC members were active in Cameroon at end-2021. Yaoundé is reached non-stop from 4 of the 19 airports we counted (Addis Ababa, Istanbul, Casablanca and Abidjan). Airline funds blocked in the CEMAC currency zone stood at US$179m in October 2025 and US$105m in March 2026. On airline reach, Central Africa is most easily served from Casablanca, Abidjan or Addis Ababa.

DR Congo. Kinshasa is reached non-stop from 10 of the 19 airports, including Addis Ababa, Nairobi, Johannesburg, Casablanca and Abidjan. The DRC belongs to the EAC, SADC and COMESA, so it can be run from an East African, Southern African or francophone hub; its own capital does not appear in the register as a regional base.

Angola and lusophone Africa. Luanda was Africa's dearest office market in Knight Frank's 2017 figures, at US$80 per sq m a month, and Mercer's 2024 survey listed it among the largest falls in expatriate cost. The kwanza lost 85% of its US$ value since end-2015, about 39% of it in the second quarter of 2023, and IATA listed US$73m of Angolan airline funds as blocked in March 2026. The new airport, designed for 15m passengers a year, took over all passenger flights in 2026; its network reaches 11 capitals and TAAG flies 75% of its routes. Linklaters, for one, presents Lisbon as its hub for lusophone Africa.

ABIDJAN

+3.7%
change in the CFA franc's US$ value since end-2015

3 of 5
links across the language line run from Abidjan

US$1.44m
yearly location cost of a 50-person HQ

DAKAR

3 of 15
other candidate cities reached non-stop

US$1.69m
highest headquarters location cost in our model

LUANDA

15m
passengers a year: design capacity of the new airport

CHAPTER 7

07 What to do

For a board choosing or reviewing an Africa headquarters, the evidence in this report reduces to six steps. They apply to a company entering Africa and to one whose current arrangement grew by accident.

> *Decide which part of the Africa job goes where, then choose the cities.*

A SITE-SELECTION TEST FOR AN AFRICA HEADQUARTERS

1. **Name the roles before the city.**
   List which of the five roles the Africa organisation needs: command, gateway, licence, service, bloc office. Most need three or four, rarely in one place.

2. **Set the gates, then score.**
   Apply the minimums for each role first. Only then compare the cities that pass, on cost and preference.

3. **Cost the families with the floor.**
   Model school places, executive housing and allowances for the expatriate team. In our model they outweigh office rent in every city.

4. **Hold cash where the currency holds.**
   Keep treasury and contracting in a hard-anchor or investment-grade jurisdiction, and record the time since each host's last published backlog.

5. **Plan for the language line.**
   For a pan-African mandate, put a hub on each side, or plan the routing through Addis Ababa, Abidjan or a Gulf hub.

6. **Check the airline as well as the airport.**
   Where one carrier flies 70 to 97% of a hub's routes, the headquarters' reach depends on that carrier's network decisions.

FOR

Corporates and their boards

Split the headquarters by role. Our gates point to Johannesburg, Cape Town or Casablanca for a command seat in Africa, Addis Ababa or Nairobi for a gateway, and Port Louis, Casablanca or Kigali for a licence centre.

For a pan-African mandate, pair a francophone and an anglophone hub. Casablanca and Johannesburg together reach 45 of 54 countries non-stop.

Give the largest markets, such as Egypt and Nigeria, strong local management, and set treasury policy by each host's currency regime and the time since its last published backlog.

FOR

Development finance institutions and multilaterals

Follow the pattern the regional banks already use: a seat in one city and hubs by bloc, as the AfDB and Afreximbank do.

Use seat decisions to strengthen gateways open to African travellers; Nairobi and Kigali score 0.962 and 1.000 on visa openness.

Publish regional staffing by city, so that host governments and investors can see where institutional demand sits.

IMPLICATIONS BY AUDIENCE, CONTINUED

FOR

Governments and investment agencies

Compete for a role you can win. Cairo and Tunis fit service centres, and Cairo, second on talent, is two capitals short of the gateway reach threshold; Kigali and Port Louis fit licence centres; Nairobi and Addis Ababa fit gateways.

Fix the gate you fail. Wider visa access for African travellers would bring Casablanca and Cairo closer to the gateway role; school and expatriate costs weigh on Dakar and Abidjan; and each year since the last published backlog will count for Lagos, Cairo and Addis Ababa.

Publish the register. A public list of licensed regional entities, as the CFC and Mauritius provide, is evidence investors can check.

FOR

Investors and developers

Price the headquarters package: Grade A space, international school places and executive housing within one commute. Schooling is 28 to 66% of location cost in our model.

Watch supply. About 818,000 sq m of new offices are due in Cairo by 2029, mainly in New Cairo and Sheikh Zayed, widening the choice for headquarters tenants. Dar es Salaam ran 20% vacancy in H1 2026, and Dubai's prime districts are close to full, according to one broker release.

Treat school capacity as infrastructure. Where final-grade fees reach US$37,000 to 39,000, an additional international school can change a city's headquarters cost.

WHAT TO WATCH

Dated changes that could move a city through a gate

2026	**Nairobi IFC**	Target of 150 certified firms by December 2026, against 28 in March and 15 more in July (IT Edge News; Citizen Digital)
2028	**Mauritius**	Fair Share Contribution of 5% on chargeable income above MUR 24m due to run until June 2028
2029	**Cairo**	About 818,000 sq m of offices due, mainly in New Cairo and Sheikh Zayed (Knight Frank)
2030	**Addis Ababa**	Bishoftu airport, under construction since January 2026; first opening targeted for 2030
Open	**Nigeria**	Expatriate employment levy announced in 2024 and paused for consultation; no repeal reported
2028	**Kigali**	Bugesera airport expected to open, according to RwandAir (2024)
Open	**AfCFTA**	50 states had deposited ratification by 2026; all 15 African candidate hosts are among them

HOW HEIRSTONE WORKS ON LOCATION STRATEGY

We help corporates, investors, developers and governments decide where to locate and what to build: site selection and location strategy, market and demand studies, highest and best use, feasibility and business models (DCF, IRR, NPV and Monte Carlo testing), and benchmarking of the kind in this report, across the Middle East and Africa.

Get in touch

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WHAT WE COULD NOT VERIFY

Public sources did not let us confirm the Dubai-based Middle East and Africa headquarters of several large consumer, payments and pharmaceutical groups, Johannesburg's full set of Africa headquarters, prime office and housing rents in Kigali, Tunis and Luanda, international school fees in Cairo, Port Louis and Luanda, or work-permit costs outside Kenya, Nigeria and Mauritius. The register and the index will take them in as primary sources allow; each gap is flagged where it affects a figure in this report.

NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS

Notes

Definitions

Regional headquarters: the office or entity from which an organisation manages, or holds a mandate for, Africa, a part of it, or the Middle East and Africa. **Candidate cities:** 16 African cities commonly considered for that role, with Dubai as a benchmark. **Capitals reached:** the other 53 African Union member states whose capital gateway has a scheduled non-stop passenger flight from the city's main airport. **Francophone and anglophone groups:** the four candidate cities in French-speaking or Maghreb countries and the seven in English-speaking countries; Cairo, Addis Ababa, Kigali, Port Louis and Luanda are in neither. **AVOI:** Africa Visa Openness Index. **CFC:** Casablanca Finance City. **KIFC, NIFC:** Kigali and Nairobi International Financial Centres. **GBC:** Global Business Company. **CIT, PIT:** corporate and personal income tax.

Method

Figures are as published, in the currency and period stated. Local-currency amounts are converted at 2026 rates (for example US$1 = KES 129.58, ZAR 16.66, MAD 9.92, MUR 48.0, RWF 1,478.7, NGN 1,331.3, AED 3.6725) unless stated; currency changes use 31 December 2015 and 2026. Several currencies lost much of their value over the periods compared, so US$ figures from different years are not like-for-like. Where sources conflict we give the range or the more conservative figure. Derived figures are labelled Heirstone analysis and use only the inputs shown. Single-source claims graded C by our researchers are attributed in the text. Air connectivity counts are about plus or minus 2. The register is a list of named, sourced cases and does not measure market shares.

Use of this report

This report is published for general information. It is not investment, tax, legal or relocation advice and should not be relied on as such. Ratings, rates, schedules and fees change; readers should verify them before acting. Images are illustrative. © Heirstone Consulting L.L.C-FZ, 2026.

1 THE HEADQUARTERS HAS COME APART

GE press release (30 April 2005); Tech Africa (12 October 2005); Enterprise (27 April 2026); Healio (4 February 2014); Porsche Newsroom; Retail Banker International (9 May 2011); Business Daily Africa (24 October 2021; 2 April 2026); Capital FM (28 October 2021); Bboxx via NextBillion (7 February 2024); KT Press (February 2021); The Condia (July 2022); Logistics Business Africa (14 February 2026); Financial Afrik (28 July 2025; 27 April 2026); World Finance; BizNews (4 June 2015); Infomineo, Global 500 in the Middle East and Africa, 3rd edition (May 2018) and Arabian Business (2017); Dubai Chambers (2025); African Business (June 2026); CFC Authority, Rapport d'activité 2021 and member directory (accessed 2026); Le Matin (24 January 2024); Wafir.ma (2026); Medias24 (16 March 2021); FSC Mauritius, Annual Statistical Bulletin 2024; TechCabal (19 March 2026); The New Times (4 December 2025; 2026); IT Edge News (2026); Citizen Digital (1 July 2026); official websites of the AfDB, Afreximbank, the AfCFTA Secretariat, UNON, AFC, Africa50, Africa CDC, Shelter Afrique, ATIDI, Airtel Africa, Vivo Energy and MTN (2026); UK Companies House (2026); GeoNames (positions); headline-only items from Kenya News Agency, EU Neighbours South, Moodie Davitt, African Business, FIPP, Linklaters and Brandcom.

2 REACH

FlightConnections airport and route pages (accessed 2026), counted by Heirstone against the African Union capital list; France Aviation Civile Services, Air Transport Data Bulletin (2026); GeoNames (airport positions); Zaha Hadid Architects (2026); China Daily (2023) and O País (2026) on Luanda; The New Times (2024) on Bugesera; ATTA citing OAG (6 January 2026); AfDB and AU, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025.

3 COST

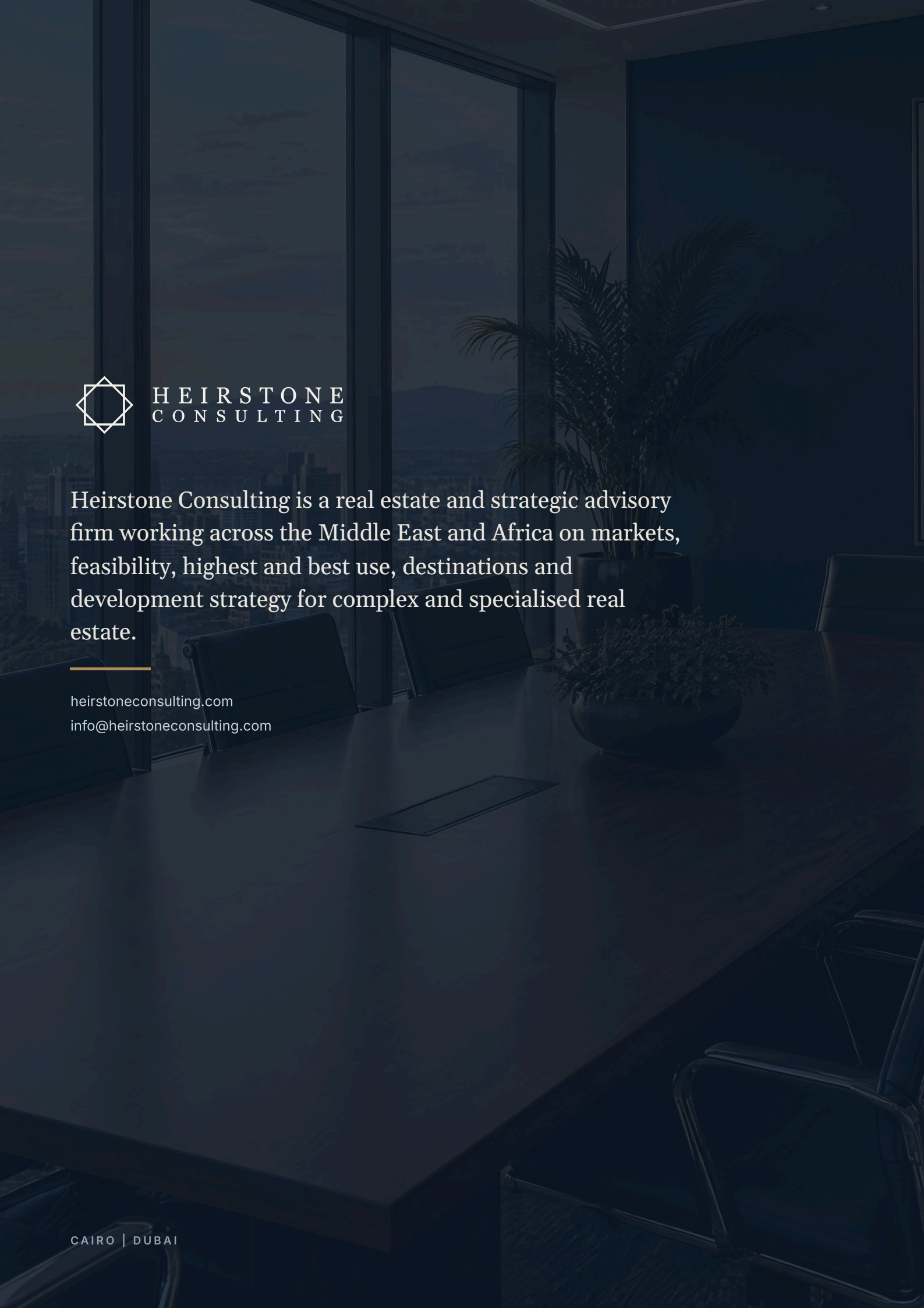
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4 CURRENCY

IMF Representative Exchange Rates (December 2015, September 2026); Exchange-Rates.org; World Bank WDI (updated 2026); Trading Economics rating lists (2026); RDB (3 October 2024) and Le360 (7 October 2024) on B-READY 2024; US Treasury, Reporting Rates of Exchange (2016 to 2026); Morocco Ministry of Economy and Finance (2015); Hespress (2024); tralac, Status of AfCFTA Ratification (2026); PIIE (9 August 2024); Bloomberg (2017; January 2023); Financial Edge; The Gazette (2 June 2024); IATA (10 December 2025); CAPA (30 April 2026); Semafor (12 December 2023); Nairametrics (4 September 2026); Africa Check (20 June 2024); Business Daily Africa (9 May 2024); AllAfrica (29 January 2025); KT Press and The Star (March 2024).

5 TO 7 INDEX, ROLES, REGIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Heirstone analysis of the sources listed for chapters 1 to 4, with World Bank WDI GDP for 2025; bloc memberships from AllAfrica (ECOWAS, 29 January 2025), KT Press and The Star (EAC, March 2024) and standard membership lists for SADC, SACU, COMESA, WAEMU and AMU.



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